As a Man Thinketh

JAMES ALLEN

As a Man Thinketh

& Out from the Heart

ANNOTATED EDITION

Two classics on the power of thought
with a plain-language note on every chapter
and a 30-day practice

INTRODUCTION AND NOTES BY ANDREAS RUPP

As a Man Thinketh and Out from the Heart (Annotated)
James Allen's Two Classics on the Power of Thought – with a Plain-Language Note on Every Chapter and a 30-Day Practice

As a Man Thinketh (1903) and *Out from the Heart* (1904) by James Allen (1864–1912) are in the public domain. This edition follows the early American printings; Allen's wording and spelling are kept, the tables in *Out from the Heart* are set as lists, and obvious printing errors are corrected.

Introduction, biography, a note on every chapter, practices, the 30-Day Practice, the Quick Finder, the glossary, the afterword, cover and interior design © 2026 Andreas Rupp. All rights reserved.

Please note: This book is about a practice of thought and character. It is not medical, psychological, financial or legal advice. The practices in this book can go alongside professional help, never instead of it. If you are ill or in crisis, please see a doctor or a qualified professional. In an emergency, call 911 (US) or 999 (UK).

Edited by Andreas Rupp

Man is the keeper of his heart; the watcher of his mind; the solitary sentinel of his citadel of life.

JAMES ALLEN, OUT FROM THE HEART

Contents

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Book 9
Who Was James Allen? 11
The Ideas in Brief 13
A Note on This Text 15

AS A MAN THINKETH

Foreword 19
Thought and Character 20
Effect of Thought on Circumstances 24
Effect of Thought on Health and the Body 34
Thought and Purpose 38
The Thought-Factor in Achievement 42
Visions and Ideals 47
Serenity 52

OUT FROM THE HEART

The Heart and the Life 57
The Nature and Power of Mind 60
Formation of Habit 64
Doing and Knowing 68
First Steps in the Higher Life 72
Mental Conditions and their Effects 84
Exhortation 89

PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE

The 30-Day Practice 93

Quick Finder 125

AFTER THE BOOK

A Glossary 127
Afterword: The Gardener of the Mind 131
Further Reading 133

How to Use This Book

This is a small book that rewards slow reading. James Allen wrote in short, dense paragraphs, and many of his sentences are meant to be turned over in the mind rather than hurried past. You can read the whole volume in an evening, but you will get far more from it if you give it time.

A simple way to begin is to read one chapter a day for two weeks. If you prefer a gentler pace, take one chapter a week and live with it for seven days before moving on. Either way, read the chapter once straight through, then go back and mark the lines that stop you.

Here is how this edition is built.

Both complete texts. You will find *As a Man Thinketh* (1903) and its companion, *Out from the Heart* (1904), printed in full. Allen's words are left as he wrote them.

A note after every chapter. Each chapter is followed by three short sections. The *Reflection* puts Allen's main point into plain modern language and asks what it might mean for a life today. The *Practice* offers one small, concrete thing to try in an ordinary day. The *Key Thought* gives you a single line from the chapter to carry with you. Below it there is room for your own notes. Use it. Writing down what you noticed, even a sentence, is often where the real learning happens.

The 30-Day Practice. After the two books comes a guided month of short daily exercises. Each day pairs one passage from Allen with a simple task and a space to write. The month moves from noticing your thoughts, to thought and circumstance, to habit and speech, to vision,

calm and kindness, and ends with two days of review. You can start it at any point, even before you have finished the books.

The Quick Finder. If you come to this book on a hard day, looking for help with worry, anger, drift or discouragement, the Quick Finder points you to the chapters and practice days that speak most directly to that situation.

The Glossary. Allen's English is more than a century old. Words like *equipoise*, *captiousness* and *rectitude* are explained at the back of the book, along with a few names and places.

One last suggestion: read with a pencil, and read with patience toward yourself. Allen asks a lot of his readers. You do not have to agree with every line to find a good deal here that is worth keeping.

Who Was James Allen?

James Allen is one of those writers whose words are far better known than his life. Lines from *As a Man Thinketh* turn up in sermons, business seminars, sports locker rooms and social media feeds, often with no name attached. Yet the man behind them lived quietly, wrote steadily, and died young.

He was born in 1864 in Leicester, in the English Midlands, a town whose working life then centered on the making of hosiery and other textiles. His family was not wealthy, and he left school early to earn a living. For years he worked in offices, as a clerk and later as a private secretary. Nothing in that ordinary working life marked him out as a future author, but he was a serious and searching reader, drawn to questions about the inner life, about how character is formed and how a person might live with more peace and purpose.

Allen began to publish around 1901, when he was in his late thirties. His first book, *From Poverty to Power*, appeared that year, and others followed quickly. He married Lily L. Allen, who shared his interests and became his partner in his work. Together they settled in Ilfracombe, a small seaside town on the north coast of Devon in southwest England. The foreword of *As a Man Thinketh* is signed from Broad Park Avenue, Ilfracombe, and it was there that Allen did most of his writing.

In Ilfracombe Allen also wrote and edited a magazine, *The Light of Reason*, which was later renamed *The Epoch*. Through it and through his books he reached a growing circle of readers who wanted a practical, spiritual guide to daily living that was not tied to any one church.

Allen is usually counted among the writers of the New Thought movement, a broad current of late nineteenth- and early twentieth-century writing, strong in both America and Britain, which taught that the mind has a deep influence on a person's health, character and life. Allen shares that conviction, but his tone is his own. He is less interested in getting what you want than in becoming a better person. His language is full of the Bible, which his first readers knew well, and he also draws freely on Buddhist teaching; *Out from the Heart* even quotes the Buddha by name. He seems to have believed that the great religious traditions point toward the same inner discipline of purity, patience and love.

As a Man Thinketh came out in 1903. It is a very short book, and Allen himself called it "suggestive rather than explanatory." Its sequel, *Out from the Heart*, followed in 1904 and turns the same ideas into a practical course of self-training, with lists of habits to drop and virtues to build.

James Allen died in Ilfracombe in 1912, at the age of forty-seven. Lily continued to carry his work forward after his death. More than a century later, the little book he wrote in a seaside town is still in print around the world, and its central claim, that the way we think shapes the people we become, still feels both simple and demanding.

The Ideas in Brief

Allen's two books are short, but they rest on a handful of big ideas. Here they are in plain terms.

Thought shapes character. Allen's starting point is a line from the Book of Proverbs: "As a man thinketh in his heart, so is he." For Allen, character is not something handed to us. It is built, slowly, out of the thoughts we return to again and again. Our actions grow from those thoughts the way a plant grows from a seed.

The mind is a garden. Allen's best-known image is of the mind as a garden that will grow something whether we tend it or not. If we plant nothing on purpose, weeds will arrive on their own. The work is not to force the mind into perfection, but to notice what is growing and to keep planting better seeds.

Cause and effect. Allen believed that the inner life follows laws as reliable as those of nature. Kind thoughts tend to produce kind acts; resentful thoughts tend to produce bitterness. Over time, he says, our inner habits show up in our outer lives.

Purpose. A mind without aim drifts and is easily pushed around by worry and self-pity. Allen urges his readers to choose a purpose, large or small, and to give their attention to it. If no great purpose is clear yet, he says, start by doing the task in front of you as well as you can.

Habit. In *Out from the Heart* Allen points out that every settled state of mind, cheerful or gloomy, calm or angry, is a habit, and that habits can be changed by patient practice. What feels hard at first becomes natural in time, as a child's handwriting does.

Serenity. The goal of all this inner work is not success for its own sake but a calm, steady, kindly mind, one that can weather storms and be a shelter for others.

Where to read carefully. Allen wrote with great confidence, and some of his claims go further than a modern reader should follow. He sometimes speaks as if illness were simply the result of wrong thinking, and as if poverty or suffering always reveal a fault in the person who suffers. These ideas need care. Stress, worry and habits really do affect our health, and calm and good habits really do help. But illness is not a person's fault, and thinking alone does not cure disease. If you are unwell, see a doctor. In the same way, our thoughts shape how we respond to what happens and the choices we make, but injustice, accidents, illness and poverty are real, and no one should be blamed for them. Allen sometimes links right thinking with prosperity, but he measures a good life by "blessedness, not material possessions," and this edition makes no promise that any way of thinking will bring wealth. Finally, watching your thoughts can be a real help, but it is not a substitute for therapy or medical care. If you are struggling with depression, anxiety or other mental health concerns, please reach out to a qualified professional.

Read this way, Allen is less a guarantee of outcomes and more a patient teacher of attention, honesty and self-respect.

A Note on This Text

This volume brings together two books by James Allen. *As a Man Thinketh* was first published in 1903; *Out from the Heart* followed in 1904. Both are printed here complete, with Allen's own wording and his British spelling, so you will meet "favour," "harbour" and "moulder" alongside a few American forms from the early printings.

Allen writes, as most authors of his time did, of "man" and "a man" when he means every human being. In his usage "man" means humankind, women and men alike, and every reader is included in what he says.

Out from the Heart contains several of Allen's own tables: the vices and virtues of the "First Steps in the Higher Life" and the wrong and right mental conditions with their effects. In this edition they are set as simple lists and short headed sections so that they read clearly on the page and on a screen. Their content has not been changed.

Allen's text quotes others in a few places: verses from the Dhammapada, an early Buddhist collection, a poem on the human will, a saying of the Buddha, and a passage from the writer Stanton Kirkham Davis. These are set apart as Allen set them.

Each of the two part pages carries a six-line verse motto that sums up the book that follows. Everything after the chapters, and every note that follows a chapter, is new to this edition.

As a Man Thinketh

1903 · SEVEN CHAPTERS

Mind is the Master power that moulds and makes,
And Man is Mind, and evermore he takes
The tool of Thought, and, shaping what he wills,
Brings forth a thousand joys, a thousand ills:—
He thinks in secret, and it comes to pass:
Environment is but his looking-glass.

Foreword

THIS LITTLE volume (the result of meditation and experience) is not intended as an exhaustive treatise on the much-written-upon subject of the power of thought. It is suggestive rather than explanatory, its object being to stimulate men and women to the discovery and perception of the truth that—

"They themselves are makers of themselves."

by virtue of the thoughts, which they choose and encourage; that mind is the master-weaver, both of the inner garment of character and the outer garment of circumstance, and that, as they may have hitherto woven in ignorance and pain they may now weave in enlightenment and happiness.

JAMES ALLEN.

Broad Park Avenue, Ilfracombe, England

CHAPTER

I

Thought and Character

THE APHORISM, "As a man thinketh in his heart so is he," not only embraces the whole of a man's being, but is so comprehensive as to reach out to every condition and circumstance of his life. A man is literally *what he thinks,* his character being the complete sum of all his thoughts.

As the plant springs from, and could not be without, the seed, so every act of a man springs from the hidden seeds of thought, and could not have appeared without them. This applies equally to those acts called "spontaneous" and "unpremeditated" as to those, which are deliberately executed.

Act is the blossom of thought, and joy and suffering are its fruits; thus does a man garner in the sweet and bitter fruitage of his own husbandry.

> "*Thought in the mind hath made us, What we are*
> *By thought was wrought and built. If a man's mind*
> *Hath evil thoughts, pain comes on him as comes*
> *The wheel the ox behind....*
>
> *..If one endure*
> *In purity of thought, joy follows him*

As his own shadow—sure."

Man is a growth by law, and not a creation by artifice, and cause and effect is as absolute and undeviating in the hidden realm of thought as in the world of visible and material things. A noble and Godlike character is not a thing of favour or chance, but is the natural result of continued effort in right thinking, the effect of long-cherished association with Godlike thoughts. An ignoble and bestial character, by the same process, is the result of the continued harbouring of grovelling thoughts.

Man is made or unmade by himself; in the armoury of thought he forges the weapons by which he destroys himself; he also fashions the tools with which he builds for himself heavenly mansions of joy and strength and peace. By the right choice and true application of thought, man ascends to the Divine Perfection; by the abuse and wrong application of thought, he descends below the level of the beast. Between these two extremes are all the grades of character, and man is their maker and master.

Of all the beautiful truths pertaining to the soul which have been restored and brought to light in this age, none is more gladdening or fruitful of divine promise and confidence than this—that man is the master of thought, the moulder of character, and the maker and shaper of condition, environment, and destiny.

As a being of Power, Intelligence, and Love, and the lord of his own thoughts, man holds the key to every situation, and contains within himself that transforming and regenerative agency by which he may make himself what he wills.

Man is always the master, even in his weaker and most abandoned state; but in his weakness and degradation he is the foolish master who misgoverns his "household." When he begins to reflect upon his condition, and to search diligently for the Law upon which his being is established, he then becomes the wise master, directing his energies with intelligence, and fashioning his thoughts to fruitful issues. Such is the *conscious* master, and man can only thus become by discovering *within*

himself the laws of thought; which discovery is totally a matter of application, self analysis, and experience.

Only by much searching and mining, are gold and diamonds obtained, and man can find every truth connected with his being, if he will dig deep into the mine of his soul; and that he is the maker of his character, the moulder of his life, and the builder of his destiny, he may unerringly prove, if he will watch, control, and alter his thoughts, tracing their effects upon himself, upon others, and upon his life and circumstances, linking cause and effect by patient practice and investigation, and utilizing his every experience, even to the most trivial, everyday occurrence, as a means of obtaining that knowledge of himself which is Understanding, Wisdom, Power. In this direction, as in no other, is the law absolute that "He that seeketh findeth; and to him that knocketh it shall be opened;" for only by patience, practice, and ceaseless importunity can a man enter the Door of the Temple of Knowledge.



REFLECTION

Allen opens with his central claim: who we are is built, day by day, out of what we habitually think. He uses the picture of a seed. Every action, even the ones that seem to come from nowhere, grew from a thought that was planted earlier. Good character, in this view, is not luck or a gift handed to a few people. It is the slow result of choosing better thoughts again and again, the way a craftsman forges his tools.

The hopeful part is that this makes us the makers, not the victims, of our inner life. Allen does not ask for blind faith. He asks us to test the idea: watch your thoughts, notice what follows from them, and learn from even the smallest moments of an ordinary day. Today we might call this self-awareness. For Allen it was also a spiritual search, a door that opens to anyone who keeps knocking.

PRACTICE

Three times today, at set moments (morning coffee, lunch, evening), stop and write down the thought that was in your mind just before. Do not judge it. Simply note it, and next to it write one word for how it made you feel.

KEY THOUGHT

Act is the blossom of thought, and joy and suffering are its fruits

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MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

II

Effect of Thought on Circumstances

MAN'S MIND may be likened to a garden, which may be intelligently cultivated or allowed to run wild; but whether cultivated or neglected, it must, and will, *bring forth.* If no useful seeds are *put* into it, then an abundance of useless weed-seeds will *fall* therein, and will continue to produce their kind.

Just as a gardener cultivates his plot, keeping it free from weeds, and growing the flowers and fruits which he requires, so may a man tend the garden of his mind, weeding out all the wrong, useless, and impure thoughts, and cultivating toward perfection the flowers and fruits of right, useful, and pure thoughts. By pursuing this process, a man sooner or later discovers that he is the master-gardener of his soul, the director of his life. He also reveals, within himself, the laws of thought, and understands, with ever-increasing accuracy, how the thought-forces and mind elements operate in the shaping of his character, circumstances, and destiny.

Thought and character are one, and as character can only manifest and discover itself through environment and circumstance, the outer conditions of a person's life will always be found to be harmoniously related to his inner state. This does not mean that a man's circumstances

at any given time are an indication of his *entire* character, but that those circumstances are so intimately connected with some vital thought-element within himself that, for the time being, they are indispensable to his development.

Every man is where he is by the law of his being; the thoughts which he has built into his character have brought him there, and in the arrangement of his life there is no element of chance, but all is the result of a law which cannot err. This is just as true of those who feel "out of harmony" with their surroundings as of those who are contented with them.

As a progressive and evolving being, man is where he is that he may learn that he may grow; and as he learns the spiritual lesson which any circumstance contains for him, it passes away and gives place to other circumstances.

Man is buffeted by circumstances so long as he believes himself to be the creature of outside conditions, but when he realizes that he is a creative power, and that he may command the hidden soil and seeds of his being out of which circumstances grow, he then becomes the rightful master of himself.

That circumstances grow out of thought every man knows who has for any length of time practised self-control and self-purification, for he will have noticed that the alteration in his circumstances has been in exact ratio with his altered mental condition. So true is this that when a man earnestly applies himself to remedy the defects in his character, and makes swift and marked progress, he passes rapidly through a succession of vicissitudes.

The soul attracts that which it secretly harbours; that which it loves, and also that which it fears; it reaches the height of its cherished aspirations; it falls to the level of its unchastened desires,—and circumstances are the means by which the soul receives its own.

Every thought-seed sown or allowed to fall into the mind, and to take root there, produces its own, blossoming sooner or later into act, and

bearing its own fruitage of opportunity and circumstance. Good thoughts bear good fruit, bad thoughts bad fruit.

The outer world of circumstance shapes itself to the inner world of thought, and both pleasant and unpleasant external conditions are factors, which make for the ultimate good of the individual. As the reaper of his own harvest, man learns both by suffering and bliss.

Following the inmost desires, aspirations, thoughts, by which he allows himself to be dominated, (pursuing the will-o'-the-wisps of impure imaginings or steadfastly walking the highway of strong and high endeavour), a man at last arrives at their fruition and fulfilment in the outer conditions of his life. The laws of growth and adjustment everywhere obtains.

A man does not come to the almshouse or the jail by the tyranny of fate or circumstance, but by the pathway of grovelling thoughts and base desires. Nor does a pure-minded man fall suddenly into crime by stress of any mere external force; the criminal thought had long been secretly fostered in the heart, and the hour of opportunity revealed its gathered power. Circumstance does not make the man; it reveals him to himself No such conditions can exist as descending into vice and its attendant sufferings apart from vicious inclinations, or ascending into virtue and its pure happiness without the continued cultivation of virtuous aspirations; and man, therefore, as the lord and master of thought, is the maker of himself the shaper and author of environment. Even at birth the soul comes to its own and through every step of its earthly pilgrimage it attracts those combinations of conditions which reveal itself, which are the reflections of its own purity and, impurity, its strength and weakness.

Men do not attract that which they *want,* but that which they *are.* Their whims, fancies, and ambitions are thwarted at every step, but their inmost thoughts and desires are fed with their own food, be it foul or clean. The "divinity that shapes our ends" is in ourselves; it is our very self. Only himself manacles man: thought and action are the gaolers of

Fate—they imprison, being base; they are also the angels of Freedom—they liberate, being noble. Not what he wishes and prays for does a man get, but what he justly earns. His wishes and prayers are only gratified and answered when they harmonize with his thoughts and actions.

In the light of this truth, what, then, is the meaning of "fighting against circumstances?" It means that a man is continually revolting against an *effect* without, while all the time he is nourishing and preserving its *cause* in his heart. That cause may take the form of a conscious vice or an unconscious weakness; but whatever it is, it stubbornly retards the efforts of its possessor, and thus calls aloud for remedy.

Men are anxious to improve their circumstances, but are unwilling to improve themselves; they therefore remain bound. The man who does not shrink from self-crucifixion can never fail to accomplish the object upon which his heart is set. This is as true of earthly as of heavenly things. Even the man whose sole object is to acquire wealth must be prepared to make great personal sacrifices before he can accomplish his object; and how much more so he who would realize a strong and well-poised life?

Here is a man who is wretchedly poor. He is extremely anxious that his surroundings and home comforts should be improved, yet all the time he shirks his work, and considers he is justified in trying to deceive his employer on the ground of the insufficiency of his wages. Such a man does not understand the simplest rudiments of those principles which are the basis of true prosperity, and is not only totally unfitted to rise out of his wretchedness, but is actually attracting to himself a still deeper wretchedness by dwelling in, and acting out, indolent, deceptive, and unmanly thoughts.

Here is a rich man who is the victim of a painful and persistent disease as the result of gluttony. He is willing to give large sums of money to get rid of it, but he will not sacrifice his gluttonous desires. He wants to gratify his taste for rich and unnatural viands and have his health as well.

Such a man is totally unfit to have health, because he has not yet learned the first principles of a healthy life.

Here is an employer of labour who adopts crooked measures to avoid paying the regulation wage, and, in the hope of making larger profits, reduces the wages of his workpeople. Such a man is altogether unfitted for prosperity, and when he finds himself bankrupt, both as regards reputation and riches, he blames circumstances, not knowing that he is the sole author of his condition.

I have introduced these three cases merely as illustrative of the truth that man is the causer (though nearly always is unconsciously) of his circumstances, and that, whilst aiming at a good end, he is continually frustrating its accomplishment by encouraging thoughts and desires which cannot possibly harmonize with that end. Such cases could be multiplied and varied almost indefinitely, but this is not necessary, as the reader can, if he so resolves, trace the action of the laws of thought in his own mind and life, and until this is done, mere external facts cannot serve as a ground of reasoning.

Circumstances, however, are so complicated, thought is so deeply rooted, and the conditions of happiness vary so, vastly with individuals, that a man's entire soul-condition (although it may be known to himself) cannot be judged by another from the external aspect of his life alone. A man may be honest in certain directions, yet suffer privations; a man may be dishonest in certain directions, yet acquire wealth; but the conclusion usually formed that the one man fails *because of his particular honesty,* and that the other *prospers because of his particular dishonesty,* is the result of a superficial judgment, which assumes that the dishonest man is almost totally corrupt, and the honest man almost entirely virtuous. In the light of a deeper knowledge and wider experience such judgment is found to be erroneous. The dishonest man may have some admirable virtues, which the other does, not possess; and the honest man obnoxious vices which are absent in the other. The honest man reaps the good results of his honest thoughts and acts; he also brings upon himself

the sufferings, which his vices produce. The dishonest man likewise garners his own suffering and happiness.

It is pleasing to human vanity to believe that one suffers because of one's virtue; but not until a man has extirpated every sickly, bitter, and impure thought from his mind, and washed every sinful stain from his soul, can he be in a position to know and declare that his sufferings are the result of his good, and not of his bad qualities; and on the way to, yet long before he has reached, that supreme perfection, he will have found, working in his mind and life, the Great Law which is absolutely just, and which cannot, therefore, give good for evil, evil for good. Possessed of such knowledge, he will then know, looking back upon his past ignorance and blindness, that his life is, and always was, justly ordered, and that all his past experiences, good and bad, were the equitable outworking of his evolving, yet unevolved self.

Good thoughts and actions can never produce bad results; bad thoughts and actions can never produce good results. This is but saying that nothing can come from corn but corn, nothing from nettles but nettles. Men understand this law in the natural world, and work with it; but few understand it in the mental and moral world (though its operation there is just as simple and undeviating), and they, therefore, do not co-operate with it.

Suffering is *always* the effect of wrong thought in some direction. It is an indication that the individual is out of harmony with himself, with the Law of his being. The sole and supreme use of suffering is to purify, to burn out all that is useless and impure. Suffering ceases for him who is pure. There could be no object in burning gold after the dross had been removed, and a perfectly pure and enlightened being could not suffer.

The circumstances, which a man encounters with suffering, are the result of his own mental inharmony. The circumstances, which a man encounters with blessedness, are the result of his own mental harmony. Blessedness, not material possessions, is the measure of right thought; wretchedness, not lack of material possessions, is the measure of wrong

thought. A man may be cursed and rich; he may be blessed and poor. Blessedness and riches are only joined together when the riches are rightly and wisely used; and the poor man only descends into wretchedness when he regards his lot as a burden unjustly imposed.

Indigence and indulgence are the two extremes of wretchedness. They are both equally unnatural and the result of mental disorder. A man is not rightly conditioned until he is a happy, healthy, and prosperous being; and happiness, health, and prosperity are the result of a harmonious adjustment of the inner with the outer, of the man with his surroundings.

A man only begins to be a man when he ceases to whine and revile, and commences to search for the hidden justice which regulates his life. And as he adapts his mind to that regulating factor, he ceases to accuse others as the cause of his condition, and builds himself up in strong and noble thoughts; ceases to kick against circumstances, but begins to *use* them as aids to his more rapid progress, and as a means of discovering the hidden powers and possibilities within himself.

Law, not confusion, is the dominating principle in the universe; justice, not injustice, is the soul and substance of life; and righteousness, not corruption, is the moulding and moving force in the spiritual government of the world. This being so, man has but to right himself to find that the universe is right; and during the process of putting himself right he will find that as he alters his thoughts towards things and other people, things and other people will alter towards him.

The proof of this truth is in every person, and it therefore admits of easy investigation by systematic introspection and self-analysis. Let a man radically alter his thoughts, and he will be astonished at the rapid transformation it will effect in the material conditions of his life. Men imagine that thought can be kept secret, but it cannot; it rapidly crystallizes into habit, and habit solidifies into circumstance. Bestial thoughts crystallize into habits of drunkenness and sensuality, which solidify into circumstances of destitution and disease: impure thoughts

of every kind crystallize into enervating and confusing habits, which solidify into distracting and adverse circumstances: thoughts of fear, doubt, and indecision crystallize into weak, unmanly, and irresolute habits, which solidify into circumstances of failure, indigence, and slavish dependence: lazy thoughts crystallize into habits of uncleanliness and dishonesty, which solidify into circumstances of foulness and beggary: hateful and condemnatory thoughts crystallize into habits of accusation and violence, which solidify into circumstances of injury and persecution: selfish thoughts of all kinds crystallize into habits of self-seeking, which solidify into circumstances more or less distressing. On the other hand, beautiful thoughts of all kinds crystallize into habits of grace and kindliness, which solidify into genial and sunny circumstances: pure thoughts crystallize into habits of temperance and self-control, which solidify into circumstances of repose and peace: thoughts of courage, self-reliance, and decision crystallize into manly habits, which solidify into circumstances of success, plenty, and freedom: energetic thoughts crystallize into habits of cleanliness and industry, which solidify into circumstances of pleasantness: gentle and forgiving thoughts crystallize into habits of gentleness, which solidify into protective and preservative circumstances: loving and unselfish thoughts crystallize into habits of self-forgetfulness for others, which solidify into circumstances of sure and abiding prosperity and true riches.

A particular train of thought persisted in, be it good or bad, cannot fail to produce its results on the character and circumstances. A man cannot *directly* choose his circumstances, but he can choose his thoughts, and so indirectly, yet surely, shape his circumstances.

Nature helps every man to the gratification of the thoughts, which he most encourages, and opportunities are presented which will most speedily bring to the surface both the good and evil thoughts.

Let a man cease from his sinful thoughts, and all the world will soften towards him, and be ready to help him; let him put away his weakly and sickly thoughts, and lo, opportunities will spring up on every hand to

aid his strong resolves; let him encourage good thoughts, and no hard fate shall bind him down to wretchedness and shame. The world is your kaleidoscope, and the varying combinations of colours, which at every succeeding moment it presents to you are the exquisitely adjusted pictures of your ever-moving thoughts.

"So You will be what you will to be;
Let failure find its false content
In that poor word, 'environment,'
But spirit scorns it, and is free.

"It masters time, it conquers space;
It cowes that boastful trickster, Chance,
And bids the tyrant Circumstance
Uncrown, and fill a servant's place.

"The human Will, that force unseen,
The offspring of a deathless Soul,
Can hew a way to any goal,
Though walls of granite intervene.

"Be not impatient in delays
But wait as one who understands;
When spirit rises and commands
The gods are ready to obey."

✦

REFLECTION

Here Allen gives his best-known image: the mind is a garden. If we plant nothing on purpose, weeds will grow anyway. A good gardener pulls the weeds and tends the flowers, and in the same way we can pull up worry, resentment and self-pity and grow patience, honesty and courage.

He then goes further and says our outer life matches our inner state. There is real truth here: our habits of thought shape our choices, our work and our relationships, and those shape much of our life. But a careful reader should not take his strongest lines literally. Poverty, injustice, illness and accidents are real, and people who suffer them are not to blame. Allen himself admits that no one can judge another person's life from the outside. The useful lesson is about response: we cannot choose every circumstance, but we can choose how we meet it and what we do next.

PRACTICE

Pick one situation that frustrates you right now. On paper, draw a line down the middle. On the left, list what you cannot control. On the right, list what you can: one thought, one habit, one next step. Do the smallest step today.

KEY THOUGHT

a man sooner or later discovers that he is the master-gardener of his soul, the director of his life.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

III

Effect of Thought on Health and the Body

THE BODY is the servant of the mind. It obeys the operations of the mind, whether they be deliberately chosen or automatically expressed. At the bidding of unlawful thoughts the body sinks rapidly into disease and decay; at the command of glad and beautiful thoughts it becomes clothed with youthfulness and beauty.

Disease and health, like circumstances, are rooted in thought. Sickly thoughts will express themselves through a sickly body. Thoughts of fear have been known to kill a man as speedily as a bullet, and they are continually killing thousands of people just as surely though less rapidly. The people who live in fear of disease are the people who get it. Anxiety quickly demoralizes the whole body, and lays it open to the entrance of disease; while impure thoughts, even if not physically indulged, will soon shatter the nervous system.

Strong, pure, and happy thoughts build up the body in vigour and grace. The body is a delicate and plastic instrument, which responds readily to the thoughts by which it is impressed, and habits of thought will produce their own effects, good or bad, upon it.

Men will continue to have impure and poisoned blood, so long as they propagate unclean thoughts. Out of a clean heart comes a clean life

and a clean body. Out of a defiled mind proceeds a defiled life and a corrupt body. Thought is the fount of action, life, and manifestation; make the fountain pure, and all will be pure.

Change of diet will not help a man who will not change his thoughts. When a man makes his thoughts pure, he no longer desires impure food.

Clean thoughts make clean habits. The so-called saint who does not wash his body is not a saint. He who has strengthened and purified his thoughts does not need to consider the malevolent microbe.

If you would protect your body, guard your mind. If you would renew your body, beautify your mind. Thoughts of malice, envy, disappointment, despondency, rob the body of its health and grace. A sour face does not come by chance; it is made by sour thoughts. Wrinkles that mar are drawn by folly, passion, and pride.

I know a woman of ninety-six who has the bright, innocent face of a girl. I know a man well under middle age whose face is drawn into inharmonious contours. The one is the result of a sweet and sunny disposition; the other is the outcome of passion and discontent.

As you cannot have a sweet and wholesome abode unless you admit the air and sunshine freely into your rooms, so a strong body and a bright, happy, or serene countenance can only result from the free admittance into the mind of thoughts of joy and goodwill and serenity.

On the faces of the aged there are wrinkles made by sympathy, others by strong and pure thought, and others are carved by passion: who cannot distinguish them? With those who have lived righteously, age is calm, peaceful, and softly mellowed, like the setting sun. I have recently seen a philosopher on his deathbed. He was not old except in years. He died as sweetly and peacefully as he had lived.

There is no physician like cheerful thought for dissipating the ills of the body; there is no comforter to compare with goodwill for dispersing the shadows of grief and sorrow. To live continually in thoughts of ill will, cynicism, suspicion, and envy, is to be confined in a self made prison-hole. But to think well of all, to be cheerful with all, to patiently

learn to find the good in all—such unselfish thoughts are the very portals of heaven; and to dwell day by day in thoughts of peace toward every creature will bring abounding peace to their possessor.

✦

REFLECTION

Allen calls the body "the servant of the mind." He believes that fear, worry and bitterness wear the body down, while cheerful and kindly thoughts help it thrive. He points to faces shaped over the years by sympathy or by discontent.

Part of this matches common experience: long-term stress, worry and poor habits do affect our sleep, our energy and our health, and calm, rest and good habits help. But Allen goes much further than anyone should. Illness is not a person's fault, and thinking good thoughts does not cure disease. If you are unwell, please see a doctor, and take any treatment you are given seriously. What we can keep from this chapter is gentler: caring for the mind is part of caring for the body. Calm, kindness and goodwill are good companions on the way to health, alongside, not instead of, real medical care.

PRACTICE

Before bed tonight, take five slow breaths and name one worry you are carrying. Then name one thing you are grateful for today. If a health worry keeps returning, make the appointment you have been putting off.

KEY THOUGHT

Clean thoughts make clean habits.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

IV

Thought and Purpose

UNTIL THOUGHT is linked with purpose there is no intelligent accomplishment. With the majority the bark of thought is allowed to "drift" upon the ocean of life. Aimlessness is a vice, and such drifting must not continue for him who would steer clear of catastrophe and destruction.

They who have no central purpose in their life fall an easy prey to petty worries, fears, troubles, and self-pityings, all of which are indications of weakness, which lead, just as surely as deliberately planned sins (though by a different route), to failure, unhappiness, and loss, for weakness cannot persist in a power evolving universe.

A man should conceive of a legitimate purpose in his heart, and set out to accomplish it. He should make this purpose the centralizing point of his thoughts. It may take the form of a spiritual ideal, or it may be a worldly object, according to his nature at the time being; but whichever it is, he should steadily focus his thought-forces upon the object, which he has set before him. He should make this purpose his supreme duty, and should devote himself to its attainment, not allowing his thoughts to wander away into ephemeral fancies, longings, and imaginings. This is the royal road to self-control and true concentration of thought. Even if he fails again and again to accomplish his purpose (as

he necessarily must until weakness is overcome), the *strength of character gained* will be the measure of *his true* success, and this will form a new starting-point for future power and triumph.

Those who are not prepared for the apprehension of a *great* purpose should fix the thoughts upon the faultless performance of their duty, no matter how insignificant their task may appear. Only in this way can the thoughts be gathered and focussed, and resolution and energy be developed, which being done, there is nothing which may not be accomplished.

The weakest soul, knowing its own weakness, and believing this truth *that strength can only be developed by effort and practice,* will, thus believing, at once begin to exert itself, and, adding effort to effort, patience to patience, and strength to strength, will never cease to develop, and will at last grow divinely strong.

As the physically weak man can make himself strong by careful and patient training, so the man of weak thoughts can make them strong by exercising himself in right thinking.

To put away aimlessness and weakness, and to begin to think with purpose, is to enter the ranks of those strong ones who only recognize failure as one of the pathways to attainment; who make all conditions serve them, and who think strongly, attempt fearlessly, and accomplish masterfully.

Having conceived of his purpose, a man should mentally mark out a *straight* pathway to its achievement, looking neither to the right nor the left. Doubts and fears should be rigorously excluded; they are disintegrating elements, which break up the straight line of effort, rendering it crooked, ineffectual, useless. Thoughts of doubt and fear never accomplished anything, and never can. They always lead to failure. Purpose, energy, power to do, and all strong thoughts cease when doubt and fear creep in.

The will to do springs from the knowledge that we *can* do. Doubt and fear are the great enemies of knowledge, and he who encourages

them, who does not slay them, thwarts himself at every step.

He who has conquered doubt and fear has conquered failure. His every thought is allied with power, and all difficulties are bravely met and wisely overcome. His purposes are seasonably planted, and they bloom and bring forth fruit, which does not fall prematurely to the ground.

Thought allied fearlessly to purpose becomes creative force: he who *knows* this is ready to become something higher and stronger than a mere bundle of wavering thoughts and fluctuating sensations; he who *does* this has become the conscious and intelligent wielder of his mental powers.

✦

REFLECTION

Without a purpose, Allen says, our thoughts drift like a boat with no one at the helm, and small worries and self-pity rush in to fill the space. His answer is to choose an aim and point our thinking at it. The aim can be spiritual or practical. What matters is that we have one.

He adds a kind word for anyone who feels they have no great mission. Start with the task in front of you and do it well. That alone gathers scattered energy and builds strength. He also reframes failure: even if we fall short many times, the strength of character we gain is the true success. Doubt and fear, he says, break up the straight line of effort. For a modern reader, this is a reminder that focus is a skill, built one small, honest effort at a time.

PRACTICE

Write one sentence that names an aim for this month. Underneath it, write one task for today that moves you toward it, however small. Do that task before you check the news or your messages.

KEY THOUGHT

think strongly, attempt fearlessly,
and accomplish masterfully.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

V

The Thought-Factor in Achievement

ALL THAT a man achieves and all that he fails to achieve is the direct result of his own thoughts. In a justly ordered universe, where loss of equipoise would mean total destruction, individual responsibility must be absolute. A man's weakness and strength, purity and impurity, are his own, and not another man's; they are brought about by himself, and not by another; and they can only be altered by himself, never by another. His condition is also his own, and not another man's. His suffering and his happiness are evolved from within. As he thinks, so he is; as he continues to think, so he remains.

A strong man cannot help a weaker unless that weaker is *willing* to be helped, and even then the weak man must become strong of himself; he must, by his own efforts, develop the strength which he admires in another. None but himself can alter his condition.

It has been usual for men to think and to say, "Many men are slaves because one is an oppressor; let us hate the oppressor." Now, however, there is amongst an increasing few a tendency to reverse this judgment, and to say, "One man is an oppressor because many are slaves; let us despise the slaves."

The truth is that oppressor and slave are co-operators in ignorance, and, while seeming to afflict each other, are in reality afflicting themselves. A perfect Knowledge perceives the action of law in the weakness of the oppressed and the misapplied power of the oppressor; a perfect Love, seeing the suffering, which both states entail, condemns neither; a perfect Compassion embraces both oppressor and oppressed.

He who has conquered weakness, and has put away all selfish thoughts, belongs neither to oppressor nor oppressed. He is free.

A man can only rise, conquer, and achieve by lifting up his thoughts. He can only remain weak, and abject, and miserable by refusing to lift up his thoughts.

Before a man can achieve anything, even in worldly things, he must lift his thoughts above slavish animal indulgence. He may not, in order to succeed, give up all animality and selfishness, by any means; but a portion of it must, at least, be sacrificed. A man whose first thought is bestial indulgence could neither think clearly nor plan methodically; he could not find and develop his latent resources, and would fail in any undertaking. Not having commenced to manfully control his thoughts, he is not in a position to control affairs and to adopt serious responsibilities. He is not fit to act independently and stand alone. But he is limited only by the thoughts, which he chooses.

There can be no progress, no achievement without sacrifice, and a man's worldly success will be in the measure that he sacrifices his confused animal thoughts, and fixes his mind on the development of his plans, and the strengthening of his resolution and self-reliance. And the higher he lifts his thoughts, the more manly, upright, and righteous he becomes, the greater will be his success, the more blessed and enduring will be his achievements.

The universe does not favour the greedy, the dishonest, the vicious, although on the mere surface it may sometimes appear to do so; it helps the honest, the magnanimous, the virtuous. All the great Teachers of the ages have declared this in varying forms, and to prove and know it a man

has but to persist in making himself more and more virtuous by lifting up his thoughts.

Intellectual achievements are the result of thought consecrated to the search for knowledge, or for the beautiful and true in life and nature. Such achievements may be sometimes connected with vanity and ambition, but they are not the outcome of those characteristics; they are the natural outgrowth of long and arduous effort, and of pure and unselfish thoughts.

Spiritual achievements are the consummation of holy aspirations. He who lives constantly in the conception of noble and lofty thoughts, who dwells upon all that is pure and unselfish, will, as surely as the sun reaches its zenith and the moon its full, become wise and noble in character, and rise into a position of influence and blessedness.

Achievement, of whatever kind, is the crown of effort, the diadem of thought. By the aid of self-control, resolution, purity, righteousness, and well-directed thought a man ascends; by the aid of animality, indolence, impurity, corruption, and confusion of thought a man descends.

A man may rise to high success in the world, and even to lofty altitudes in the spiritual realm, and again descend into weakness and wretchedness by allowing arrogant, selfish, and corrupt thoughts to take possession of him.

Victories attained by right thought can only be maintained by watchfulness. Many give way when success is assured, and rapidly fall back into failure.

All achievements, whether in the business, intellectual, or spiritual world, are the result of definitely directed thought, are governed by the same law and are of the same method; the only difference lies in *the object of attainment.*

He who would accomplish little must sacrifice little; he who would achieve much must sacrifice much; he who would attain highly must sacrifice greatly.

REFLECTION

In this chapter Allen links every kind of success, in business, study or the spiritual life, to the quality of our thinking. He talks about sacrifice: we gain little without giving something up, such as comfort, distraction or the urge to indulge ourselves. The more we hope to achieve, the more we must be willing to let go.

Some of his language about responsibility is very strong, and his remarks on oppressor and slave can sound harsh today. Oppression is real, and those who suffer it are not to blame. His deeper point is about freedom of mind: the person who refuses both to dominate and to hate becomes inwardly free. He also warns that success can be lost again through pride or carelessness. Good results need watchfulness to keep them. Achievement, in his phrase, is the crown of effort, and every crown is earned slowly.

PRACTICE

Name one comfort or distraction that quietly steals time from something you care about. For one day, set it aside on purpose. In the evening, write two lines about what you did with the time you gained.

KEY THOUGHT

Achievement, of whatever kind, is the crown of effort, the diadem of thought.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

VI

Visions and Ideals

THE DREAMERS are the saviours of the world. As the visible world is sustained by the invisible, so men, through all their trials and sins and sordid vocations, are nourished by the beautiful visions of their solitary dreamers. Humanity cannot forget its dreamers; it cannot let their ideals fade and die; it lives in them; it knows them as the *realities* which it shall one day see and know.

Composer, sculptor, painter, poet, prophet, sage, these are the makers of the after-world, the architects of heaven. The world is beautiful because they have lived; without them, labouring humanity would perish.

He who cherishes a beautiful vision, a lofty ideal in his heart, will one day realize it. Columbus cherished a vision of another world, and he discovered it; Copernicus fostered the vision of a multiplicity of worlds and a wider universe, and he revealed it; Buddha beheld the vision of a spiritual world of stainless beauty and perfect peace, and he entered into it.

Cherish your visions; cherish your ideals; cherish the music that stirs in your heart, the beauty that forms in your mind, the loveliness that drapes your purest thoughts, for out of them will grow all delightful

conditions, all, heavenly environment; of these, if you but remain true to them, your world will at last be built.

To desire is to obtain; to aspire is to, achieve. Shall man's basest desires receive the fullest measure of gratification, and his purest aspirations starve for lack of sustenance? Such is not the Law: such a condition of things can never obtain: "ask and receive."

Dream lofty dreams, and as you dream, so shall you become. Your Vision is the promise of what you shall one day be; your Ideal is the prophecy of what you shall at last unveil.

The greatest achievement was at first and for a time a dream. The oak sleeps in the acorn; the bird waits in the egg; and in the highest vision of the soul a waking angel stirs. Dreams are the seedlings of realities.

Your circumstances may be uncongenial, but they shall not long remain so if you but perceive an Ideal and strive to reach it. You cannot travel *within* and stand still *without.* Here is a youth hard pressed by poverty and labour; confined long hours in an unhealthy workshop; unschooled, and lacking all the arts of refinement. But he dreams of better things; he thinks of intelligence, of refinement, of grace and beauty. He conceives of, mentally builds up, an ideal condition of life; the vision of a wider liberty and a larger scope takes possession of him; unrest urges him to action, and he utilizes all his spare time and means, small though they are, to the development of his latent powers and resources. Very soon so altered has his mind become that the workshop can no longer hold him. It has become so out of harmony with his mentality that it falls out of his life as a garment is cast aside, and, with the growth of opportunities, which fit the scope of his expanding powers, he passes out of it forever. Years later we see this youth as a full-grown man. We find him a master of certain forces of the mind, which he wields with worldwide influence and almost unequalled power. In his hands he holds the cords of gigantic responsibilities; he speaks, and lo, lives are changed; men and women hang upon his words and remould their characters, and, sunlike, he becomes the fixed and luminous centre

round which innumerable destinies revolve. He has realized the Vision of his youth. He has become one with his Ideal.

And you, too, youthful reader, will realize the Vision (not the idle wish) of your heart, be it base or beautiful, or a mixture of both, for you will always gravitate toward that which you, secretly, most love. Into your hands will be placed the exact results of your own thoughts; you will receive that which you earn; no more, no less. Whatever your present environment may be, you will fall, remain, or rise with your thoughts, your Vision, your Ideal. You will become as small as your controlling desire; as great as your dominant aspiration: in the beautiful words of Stanton Kirkham Davis, "You may be keeping accounts, and presently you shall walk out of the door that for so long has seemed to you the barrier of your ideals, and shall find yourself before an audience —the pen still behind your ear, the ink stains on your fingers and then and there shall pour out the torrent of your inspiration. You may be driving sheep, and you shall wander to the city-bucolic and open-mouthed; shall wander under the intrepid guidance of the spirit into the studio of the master, and after a time he shall say, 'I have nothing more to teach you.' And now you have become the master, who did so recently dream of great things while driving sheep. You shall lay down the saw and the plane to take upon yourself the regeneration of the world."

The thoughtless, the ignorant, and the indolent, seeing only the apparent effects of things and not the things themselves, talk of luck, of fortune, and chance. Seeing a man grow rich, they say, "How lucky he is!" Observing another become intellectual, they exclaim, "How highly favoured he is!" And noting the saintly character and wide influence of another, they remark, "How chance aids him at every turn!" They do not see the trials and failures and struggles which these men have voluntarily encountered in order to gain their experience; have no knowledge of the sacrifices they have made, of the undaunted efforts they have put forth, of the faith they have exercised, that they might overcome the

apparently insurmountable, and realize the Vision of their heart. They do not know the darkness and the heartaches; they only see the light and joy, and call it "luck". They do not see the long and arduous journey, but only behold the pleasant goal, and call it "good fortune," do not understand the process, but only perceive the result, and call it chance.

In all human affairs there are *efforts,* and there are *results,* and the strength of the effort is the measure of the result. Chance is not. Gifts, powers, material, intellectual, and spiritual possessions are the fruits of effort; they are thoughts completed, objects accomplished, visions realized.

The Vision that you glorify in your mind, the Ideal that you enthrone in your heart—this you will build your life by, this you will become.



REFLECTION

This is Allen's most hopeful chapter. He honors the dreamers, the artists, thinkers and visionaries who imagine a better world before anyone can see it. A vision held in the heart, he says, is a seed, the way the oak sleeps in the acorn.

He tells the story of a poor young worker in an unhealthy workshop who uses his spare hours to grow, until the old life no longer fits him. The point is not that wishing makes things happen. Allen separates a true vision from "the idle wish," and he stresses that people who seem lucky have usually worked hard and failed often along the way. Not every dream comes true, and life is not always fair. Still, a clear ideal gives our effort direction, and patient work toward it changes us, whatever the outcome.

PRACTICE

Take ten minutes to describe, in a few sentences, the person you hope to become in five years. Then circle one quality in that description and practice it once today in a small, real way.

KEY THOUGHT

Dreams are the seedlings of realities.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

VII

Serenity

CALMNESS OF mind is one of the beautiful jewels of wisdom. It is the result of long and patient effort in self-control. Its presence is an indication of ripened experience, and of a more than ordinary knowledge of the laws and operations of thought.

A man becomes calm in the measure that he understands himself as a thought evolved being, for such knowledge necessitates the understanding of others as the result of thought, and as he develops a right understanding, and sees more and more clearly the internal relations of things by the action of cause and effect he ceases to fuss and fume and worry and grieve, and remains poised, steadfast, serene.

The calm man, having learned how to govern himself, knows how to adapt himself to others; and they, in turn, reverence his spiritual strength, and feel that they can learn of him and rely upon him. The more tranquil a man becomes, the greater is his success, his influence, his power for good. Even the ordinary trader will find his business prosperity increase as he develops a greater self-control and equanimity, for people will always prefer to deal with a man whose demeanour is strongly equable.

The strong, calm man is always loved and revered. He is like a shade-giving tree in a thirsty land, or a sheltering rock in a storm. “Who does

not love a tranquil heart, a sweet-tempered, balanced life? It does not matter whether it rains or shines, or what changes come to those possessing these blessings, for they are always sweet, serene, and calm. That exquisite poise of character, which we call serenity is the last lesson of culture, the fruitage of the soul. It is precious as wisdom, more to be desired than gold—yea, than even fine gold. How insignificant mere money seeking looks in comparison with a serene life—a life that dwells in the ocean of Truth, beneath the waves, beyond the reach of tempests, in the Eternal Calm!

"How many people we know who sour their lives, who ruin all that is sweet and beautiful by explosive tempers, who destroy their poise of character, and make bad blood! It is a question whether the great majority of people do not ruin their lives and mar their happiness by lack of self-control. How few people we meet in life who are well balanced, who have that exquisite poise which is characteristic of the finished character!

Yes, humanity surges with uncontrolled passion, is tumultuous with ungoverned grief, is blown about by anxiety and doubt only the wise man, only he whose thoughts are controlled and purified, makes the winds and the storms of the soul obey him.

Tempest-tossed souls, wherever ye may be, under whatsoever conditions ye may live, know this in the ocean of life the isles of Blessedness are smiling, and the sunny shore of your ideal awaits your coming. Keep your hand firmly upon the helm of thought. In the bark of your soul reclines the commanding Master; He does but sleep: wake Him. Self-control is strength; Right Thought is mastery; Calmness is power. Say unto your heart, "Peace, be still!"

REFLECTION

Allen closes his first book with calm. Serenity, he says, is not a mood but a hard-won strength, the fruit of long practice in self-control. The more we understand how thought shapes people, including ourselves, the less we fuss, fume and worry.

He paints the calm person as a shade tree in a dry land or a rock in a storm: someone others trust and lean on. He notices how many lives are spoiled by explosive tempers. His closing image is a boat on a rough sea, with the Master asleep inside it. Christian readers will hear the gospel story of the stilling of the storm, and the words "Peace, be still!" For any reader, the message is that a quiet center can be found again and again, even in hard times. If anxiety feels too heavy to carry alone, talking with a counselor or doctor is a wise and strong step.

PRACTICE

The next time you feel irritation rising today, pause before you speak. Take one slow breath, silently say "Peace, be still," and only then reply. Tonight, note whether the pause changed anything.

KEY THOUGHT

Self-control is strength; Right Thought is mastery; Calmness is power.

MY OWN NOTES

Out from the Heart

1904 · SEVEN CHAPTERS

Make pure thy heart, and thou wilt make thy life
Rich, sweet, and beautiful, unmarred by strife;
Guard well thy mind, and, noble, strong, and free,
Nothing shall harm, disturb, or conquer thee;
For all thy foes are in thy heart and mind.
There also thy salvation thou wilt find.

CHAPTER

I

The Heart and the Life

As the heart, so is the life. The within is ceaselessly becoming the without. Nothing remains unrevealed. That which is hidden is but for a time; it ripens and comes forth at last. Seed, tree, blossom, and fruit is the fourfold order of the universe. From the state of a man's heart proceed the conditions of his life; his thoughts blossom into deeds, and his deeds bear the fruitage of character and destiny.

Life is ever unfolding from within, and revealing itself to the light, and thoughts engendered in the heart at last reveal themselves in words, actions, and things accomplished.

As the fountain from the hidden spring, so issues man's life from the secret recesses of his heart. All that he is and does is generated there. All that he will be and do will take its rise there.

Sorrow and gladness, suffering and enjoyment, hope and fear, hatred and love, ignorance and enlightenment, are nowhere but in the heart; they are solely mental conditions.

Man is the keeper of his heart; the watcher of his mind; the solitary sentinel of his citadel of life. As such, he can be diligent or negligent. He can keep his heart more and more carefully; he can more strenuously watch and purify his mind; and he can guard himself against the thinking of unrighteous thoughts: this is the way of enlightenment and bliss.

On the other hand, he can live loosely and carelessly, neglecting the supreme task of rightly ordering his life: this is the way of self-delusion and suffering.

Let a man realize that life in its totality proceeds from the mind, and lo, the way of blessedness is opened up to him! For he will then discover that he possesses the power to rule his mind, and to fashion it in accordance with his Ideal. So will he elect to strongly and steadfastly walk those pathways of thought and action which are altogether excellent; to him life will become beautiful and sacred; and, sooner or later, he will put to flight all evil, confusion and suffering; for it is impossible for a man to fall short of liberation, enlightenment, and peace, who guards with unwearying diligence the gateway of his heart.

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REFLECTION

The second book opens by restating Allen's core idea in fewer words: our life grows out of our heart. Here "heart" means the inner self, our thoughts, desires and attitudes together. What is hidden there does not stay hidden. In time it shows up in words, choices and deeds.

His image is a guard at the gate. Each of us is the keeper of our own heart, the sentry of our inner city. We can be careful or careless. A careful keeper notices which thoughts are allowed in and which are turned away. A careless one lets anything pass and later wonders why life feels confused. This is not about being perfect. It is about paying attention. For modern readers, it is a call to treat the inner life as something worth tending, not as background noise.

PRACTICE

Choose one "gate" in your day, such as your phone, the news or a certain conversation. Before you go through it, ask yourself: "What am I letting in?" Do this three times today.

KEY THOUGHT

As the heart, so is the life.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

II

The Nature and Power of Mind

MIND IS the arbiter of life; it is the creator and shaper of conditions, and the recipient of its own results. It contains within itself both the power to create illusion and to perceive reality.

Mind is the infallible weaver of destiny; thought is the thread, good and evil deeds are the warp and woof, and the web, woven upon the loom of life, is character. Mind clothes itself in garments of its own making.

Man, as a mental being, possesses all the powers of mind, and is furnished with illimitable choice. He learns by experience, and he can accelerate or retard his experience. He is not arbitrarily bound at any point, but he has bound himself at many points, and having bound himself he can, when he chooses, liberate himself. He can become bestial or pure, ignoble or noble, foolish or wise, just as he chooses. He can, by recurring practice, form habits, and he can, by renewed effort, break them off. He can surround himself with illusions until Truth is completely lost, and he can destroy one and another of those illusions until Truth is entirely recovered. His possibilities are limitless; his freedom is complete.

It is in the nature of mind to create its own conditions, and to choose the states in which it shall dwell. It also has the power to alter any condition and to abandon any state, and this it is continually doing as it gathers knowledge of state after state by repeated choice and exhaustive experience.

Inward processes of thought make up the sum of character and life, and man can modify and alter these processes by bringing will and effort to bear upon them. The bonds of habit, impotence, and sin are self-made, and can only be destroyed by one's self; they exist nowhere but in one's mind, and although they are directly related to outward things, they have no real existence in those things. The outer is moulded and vivified by the inner, and never the inner by the outer. Temptation does not arise in the outer object, but *in the lust of the mind for that object*; nor do suffering and sorrow inhere in the external things and happenings of life, but in an undisciplined attitude of mind toward those things and happenings. The mind that is disciplined by Purity and fortified by Wisdom, avoids all those lusts and desires which are inseparably bound up with affliction, and so arrives at enlightenment and peace.

To condemn others as evil, and to rail against outside conditions as the source of evil, increases, and does not lessen, the world's suffering and unrest. The outer is but the shadow and effect of the inner, and when the heart is pure all outward things are pure.

All growth and life is from within outward; all decay and death is from without inward; this is a universal law. All evolution proceeds from within. All adjustment must take place within. He who ceases to strive against others, and employs his powers in the transformation, regeneration, and development of his own mind, conserves his energies and preserves himself; and as he succeeds in harmonizing his own mind, he leads others by consideration and charity into a like blessed state, for not by assuming authority and guidance over other minds is the way of enlightenment and peace discovered, but by exercising a lawful

authority over one's own, and by guiding one's self in pathways of steadfast and lofty virtue.

A man's life proceeds from his heart, his mind: he has compounded that mind by his own thoughts and deeds: it is in his power to refashion that mind by his choice of thought: he can therefore transform his life. Let us see how this is to be done.

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REFLECTION

Allen describes the mind as a weaver. Thought is the thread, our deeds good and bad are the pattern, and the finished cloth is our character. Mind, he says, dresses itself in clothes of its own making.

His message is about freedom. We may have bound ourselves with habits, but what we have bound we can loosen. Temptation, he argues, lives less in the object than in our craving for it, and much of our sorrow comes from the attitude we bring to events. He also warns against constantly blaming others and railing at the world, which only adds to the world's unrest. This does not mean wrong and injustice should be ignored. It means the work of change begins at home, in our own mind, and good influence on others comes more from example than from control.

PRACTICE

When you catch yourself complaining about someone today, pause and ask: "What is one thing in my own attitude I could change here?" Write down your answer, and act on it once before the day ends.

KEY THOUGHT

Mind clothes itself in garments of its own making.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

III

Formation of Habit

EVERY ESTABLISHED mental condition is an *acquired habit*, and it has become such by continuous repetition of thought. Despondency and cheerfulness, anger and calmness, covetousness and generosity—indeed, all states of mind—are habits built up by choice, until they have become automatic. A thought constantly repeated at last becomes a fixed habit of the mind, and from such habits proceeds the life.

It is in the nature of the mind to acquire knowledge by the repetition of its experiences. A thought which it is very difficult, at first, to hold and to dwell upon, at last becomes, by constantly being held in the mind, a natural and habitual condition. Just as a boy, when commencing to learn a trade, cannot even handle his tools aright, much less use them correctly, but after long repetition and practice plies them with perfect ease and consummate skill, so a state of mind, at first apparently impossible of realization, is, by perseverance and practice, at last acquired and built into the character as a natural and spontaneous condition.

In this power of the mind to form and reform its habits, its conditions, is contained the basis of man's salvation, and the open door to perfect liberty by the mastery of self, for as a man has the power to

form harmful habits, so he has the same power to create habits that are essentially good. And here we come to a point which needs some elucidating, and which calls for deep and earnest thought on the part of my reader.

It is commonly said to be easier to do wrong than right, to sin than to be holy; such condition has come to be regarded, almost universally, as axiomatic, and no less a teacher than the Buddha has said:—"Bad deeds, and deeds hurtful to ourselves, are easy to do; what is beneficial and good, that is very difficult to do,"—and as regards humanity generally, this is true, but it is only true as a passing experience, a fleeting factor in human evolution; it is not a fixed condition of things, is not of the nature of an eternal truth. It is easier for men to do wrong than right, because of the prevalence of ignorance, because the true nature of things, and the essence and meaning of life, are not apprehended. When a child is learning to write, it is extremely easy for it to hold the pen wrongly, and to form its letters incorrectly, but it is painfully difficult to hold the pen and to write properly; and this because of the child's ignorance of the art of writing, which can only be dispelled by persistent effort and practice, until, at last, it becomes natural and easy to hold the pen properly, and to write correctly, and difficult, as well as altogether unnecessary, to do the wrong thing. It is the same in the vital things of mind and life. To think and do rightly requires much practice and renewed effort, but the time at last comes when it becomes habitual and easy to think and do rightly, and difficult, as it is then seen to be altogether unnecessary, to do that which is wrong.

Just as an artisan becomes, by practice, accomplished in his craft, so a man can become, by practice, accomplished in goodness; it is entirely a matter of forming new habits of thought, and he to whom right thoughts have become easy and natural, and wrong thoughts and acts difficult to do, has attained to the highest virtue, to pure, spiritual knowledge.

It is easy and natural for men to sin, because they have formed, by incessant repetition, harmful and unenlightened habits of thought. It is very difficult for the thief to refrain from stealing when opportunity occurs, because he has lived so long in covetous and avaricious thoughts; but such difficulty does not exist for the honest man who has lived so long in upright and honest thoughts, and has thereby become enlightened as to the wrong, folly, and fruitlessness of theft, that even the remotest idea of stealing does not enter his mind. The sin of theft is a very extreme one, and I have introduced it in order to the more clearly illustrate the force and formation of habit; but all sins and virtues are formed in the same way. Anger and impatience are natural and easy to thousands of people, because they are constantly repeating the angry and impatient thought and act, and with each repetition the habit is more firmly established and more deeply rooted. Calmness and patience can become habitual in the same way—by first grasping through effort, a calm and patient thought, and then continuously thinking it, and living in it, until "use becomes second nature," and anger and impatience pass away for ever. It is thus that every wrong thought may be expelled from the mind; thus that every untrue act may be destroyed; thus that every sin may be overcome.

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REFLECTION

Every settled mood, Allen says, is a habit. Cheerfulness and gloom, calm and anger, generosity and greed are all built by repetition until they run on their own. That is the bad news and the good news together: the same power that formed a harmful habit can form a helpful one.

He compares this to learning a trade or learning to write. At first the pen feels awkward and mistakes come easily. With practice the right way becomes natural, and the wrong way starts to feel strange. Allen admits that doing right often feels harder than doing wrong, but he sees this as a stage, not a law of life.

The practical hope is clear: patience, calm and kindness can be practiced like any skill, and each repetition makes the next one easier.

PRACTICE

Pick one small calm habit to repeat today, such as a slow breath before answering a message. Do it every time the moment comes. Keep a simple tally on paper and count the marks tonight.

KEY THOUGHT

Calmness and patience can become habitual in the same way

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

IV

Doing and Knowing

LET A man realize that his life, in its totality, proceeds from his mind, and that that mind is a combination of habits which he can, by patient effort, modify to any extent, and over which he can thus gain complete ascendancy and control, and he has at once obtained possession of the key which shall open the door to his complete emancipation.

But emancipation from the ills of life (which are the ills of one's mind) is a matter of steady growth from within, and not a sudden acquisition from without. Hourly and daily must the mind be trained to think stainless thoughts, and to adopt right and dispassionate attitudes under those circumstances in which it is prone to fall into wrong and passion. Like the patient sculptor upon his marble, the aspirant to the Right Life must gradually work upon the crude material of his mind until he has wrought out of it the Ideal of his holiest dreams.

In working toward such supreme accomplishment, it is necessary to commence at the lowest and easiest steps, and proceed by natural and progressive stages to the higher and more difficult. This law of growth, progress, evolution, unfoldment, by gradual and ever ascending stages, is absolute in every department of life, and in every human accomplishment, and where it is ignored, total failure will result. In

acquiring learning, in learning a trade, or in pursuing a business, this law is fully recognized and minutely obeyed by all; but in acquiring Virtue, in learning Truth, and in pursuing the right conduct and knowledge of life, it is unrecognized and disobeyed by nearly all; hence Virtue, Truth, and the Perfect Life remain unpractised, unacquired, and unknown.

It is a common error to suppose that the Higher Life is a matter of reading, and the adoption of theological or metaphysical hypotheses, and that Spiritual Principles can be apprehended by this method. The Higher Life is a higher living in thought, word, and deed, and the knowledge of those Spiritual Principles, which are immanent in man and in the universe can only be acquired after long discipline in the pursuit and practice of Virtue.

The lesser must be thoroughly grasped and understood before the greater can be known, and practice always precedes real knowledge. The schoolmaster never attempts to teach his pupils the abstract principles of mathematics at the commencement; he knows that by such a method teaching would be vain, and learning impossible. He first places before them a simple sum, and, having explained it, leaves them to do it. When, after repeated failures and ever-renewed effort, they have succeeded in doing it correctly, a more difficult task is set them, and then another and another; and not until the pupils have, through many years of diligent application, mastered all the lessons in arithmetic, does he attempt to unfold to them the underlying mathematical principles.

In learning a trade, say that of a mechanic, the boy is not at first taught the principles of mechanics, but a simple tool is put into his hand and he is told how rightly to use it, and is then left to do it by effort and practice. As he succeeds in plying his tools correctly, more and more difficult tasks are set him, until, after several years of successful practice, he is prepared to study and grasp the principles of mechanics.

In a properly governed household, the child is first taught to be obedient, and to conduct itself properly under all circumstances. The child is not even told why it must do this, but is commanded to do it,

and only after it has so far succeeded in doing what is right and proper, is it told why it should do it. No father would attempt to teach his child the principles of ethics before exacting from it the practice of filial duty and social virtue.

Thus practice ever precedes knowledge even in the ordinary things of the world, and in spiritual things, in the living of the Higher Life, this law is rigid in its exactions. Virtue can only be known by doing, and the knowledge of Truth can only be arrived at by perfecting oneself in the practice of Virtue and to be complete in the practice and acquisition of Virtue is to be complete in the knowledge of Truth.

Truth can only be arrived at by daily and hourly doing the lessons of Virtue, beginning at the simplest, and passing on to the more difficult; and as a child patiently and obediently learns its lessons at school, constantly practising, ever exerting itself until all failures and difficulties are surmounted, even so does the child of Truth apply himself to right-doing in thought and action, undaunted by failure, and made stronger by difficulties; and as he succeeds in acquiring Virtue, his mind unfolds itself in the knowledge of Truth, and it is a knowledge in which he can securely rest.



REFLECTION

Allen's point here is simple: we learn by doing, not just by reading. Nobody becomes a mechanic by studying theory first. They pick up a tool and practice. A pupil learns sums before the principles of mathematics. In the same way, he says, goodness and wisdom are learned by practice, starting with the easiest steps.

This is a useful warning for anyone who loves books about self-improvement, this one included. Knowing about patience is not the same as being patient. Allen calls the inner life a matter of steady growth, like a sculptor slowly shaping marble. Real change comes from small daily actions, repeated

over time. His example of the obedient child reflects his era, and parents today may teach differently, but the core lesson still stands: practice comes first, and understanding follows.

PRACTICE

Choose one idea from this book that you agree with. Instead of reading further today, turn it into one specific action and do it. Afterward, write one sentence about what you learned from doing it.

KEY THOUGHT

practice always precedes real knowledge.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

V

First Steps in the Higher Life

SEEING THAT the Path of Virtue is the Path of Knowledge, and that before the all-embracing Principles of Truth can be comprehended, perfection in the more lowly steps must be acquired, how, then, shall a disciple of Truth commence? How shall one who aspires to the righting of his mind and the purification of his heart—that heart which is the fountain and repository of all the issues of life—learn the lessons of Virtue, and thus build himself up in the strength of knowledge, destroying ignorance and the ills of life? What are the first lessons, the first steps? How are they learned? How are they practised? How are they mastered and understood?

The first lessons consist in overcoming those wrong mental conditions which are the most easily eradicated, and which are the common barriers to spiritual progress, as well as in practising the simple domestic and social virtues; and the reader will be the better aided if I group and classify the first ten steps in three lessons as follows:—

VICES TO BE OVERCOME AND ERADICATED

Vices of the Body — *First Lesson: Discipline of the Body*

1. Indolence.

2. Self-indulgence.

Vices of the Tongue — *Second Lesson: Discipline of Speech*

1. Slander.
2. Gossip and idle conversation.
3. Abusive and unkind speech.
4. Levity, or irreverent speech.
5. Captiousness, or fault-finding speech.

VIRTUES TO BE PRACTICED AND ACQUIRED

Third Lesson: Discipline of Inclination

1. Unselfish performance of duty.
2. Unswerving rectitude.
3. Unlimited forgiveness.

The two vices of the body, and five of the tongue, are so called because they are manifested in the body and tongue, and also because, by so definitely classifying them, the mind of the reader will be the better helped; but it must be clearly understood that these vices arise primarily in the mind, and are wrong conditions of heart worked out in the body and the tongue.

The existence of such chaotic conditions is an indication that the mind is altogether unenlightened as to the real meaning and purpose of life, and their eradication is the beginning of a virtuous, steadfast, and enlightened life.

But how shall they be overcome and eradicated? By first, and at once, checking and controlling their outward manifestations, by suppressing the wrong act; this will stimulate the mind to watchfulness and reflection

until, by repeated practice, it will at last come to perceive and understand the dark and wrong conditions of mind, out of which such acts spring, and will abandon them entirely.

It will be seen that the first step in the discipline of the mind is the overcoming of indolence. This is the easiest step, and until it is perfectly accomplished, the other steps cannot be taken. The clinging to indolence constitutes a complete barrier to the Path of Truth. Indolence consists in giving the body more ease and sleep than it requires, in procrastinating, and in shirking and neglecting those things which should receive immediate attention. This condition of laziness must be overcome by rousing up the body at any early hour, giving it just the amount of sleep it requires for complete recuperation, and by doing promptly and vigorously, every task and duty, no matter how small, as it comes along. On no account should food or drink be taken in bed, and to lie in bed after one has wakened, indulging in ease and reverie, is a habit fatal to promptness and resolution of character, and purity of mind. Nor should one attempt to do his thinking at such a time. Strong, pure, and true thinking is impossible under such circumstances. A man should go to bed to sleep, not to think. He should get up to think and work, not to sleep.

The next step is the overcoming of self-indulgence, or gluttony. The glutton is he who eats for animal gratification only, without considering the true end and object in eating, who eats more than his body requires, and is greedy after sweet things and rich dishes. Such undisciplined desire can only be overcome by reducing the quantity of food eaten, and the number of meals per day, and by resorting to a simple and uninvolved dietary. Regular hours should be set apart for meals, and eating at other times should be rigidly avoided. Suppers should be abolished, as they are altogether unnecessary, and conduce to heavy sleep and cloudiness of mind. The pursuit of such a method of discipline will rapidly bring the hitherto ungoverned appetite under control, and as the sensual sin of self-indulgence is taken out of the mind, the right selection

of food will be instinctively and infallibly adapted to the purified mental condition.

It should be well borne in mind that change of heart is the needful thing, and that any change of diet which does not subserve this end is futile. Whilst one eats for enjoyment he is gluttonous. The heart must be purified of sensual craving and gustatory lust.

When the body is well controlled and firmly guided; when that which is to be done is done vigorously; when no task or duty is delayed; when early rising has become a delight; when frugality, temperance, and abstinence are firmly established; when one is contented with the food which is put before him, no matter how scant and plain, and the craving for gustatory pleasure is at an end,—then are the first two steps in the Higher Life accomplished; then is the first great lesson in Truth learned. Thus is established in the heart the foundation of a poised, self-governed, virtuous life.

The next lesson is the lesson of Virtuous Speech, in which are five orderly steps. The first step is the overcoming of slander. Slander consists in inventing or repeating evil reports about others, in exposing and magnifying the faults of others, or of absent friends, and in introducing unworthy insinuations. The elements of thoughtlessness, cruelty, insincerity, and untruthfulness enter into every slanderous act. He who aims at the living of the right life will commence to check the cruel word of slander before it has gone forth from his lips, and will then check and eliminate the insincere thought which gave rise to it. He will watch himself that he does not vilify any, and will refrain from disparaging and condemning the absent friend, whose face he has so recently kissed, or shaken his hand, or smiled into his face. He will not say of another that which he dare not say to him. Thus, coming at last to think sacredly of the character and reputation of others, he will destroy those wrong conditions of mind which give rise to slander.

The next step is the overcoming of gossip and idle conversation. Idle speech consists in talking about the private affairs of others, in talking

merely to pass away the time, and in engaging in aimless and irrelevant conversation. Such an ungoverned condition of speech is the outcome of an ill-regulated mind. The man of virtue will bridle his tongue, and thus learn how rightly to govern the mind. He will not let his tongue run idly and foolishly, but will make his speech strong and pure and will either talk with a purpose or remain silent.

Abusive and unkind speech is the next vice to be overcome. The man who abuses and accuses others has himself wandered far from the Right Way. To hurl hard words and names at others is to sink deeply into folly. When a man is inclined to abuse and condemn others, let him restrain his tongue and look in upon himself. The virtuous man refrains from abuse and quarrelling, and employs only words that are useful, necessary, pure, and true.

The next step is the overcoming of levity, or irreverent speech. Light and frivolous talking; the repeating of coarse jokes; the telling of vulgar stories, having no other purpose than to raise an empty laugh; offensive familiarity, and the employment of contemptuous and irreverent terms when speaking to or of others, and particularly of one's elders and those who rank as one's teachers, guardians, or superiors,—all this will be put away by the lover of Virtue and Truth.

Upon the altar of irreverence absent friends and companions are immolated for the passing excitement of a momentary laugh, and all the sanctity of life is sacrificed to the zest for ridicule. When respect towards others and the giving of reverence where reverence is due are abandoned, Virtue is abandoned. When modesty, gravity, and dignity are eliminated from speech and behavior, Truth is lost, yea, even its entrance gate is hidden away and forgotten. Irreverence is degrading even in the young, but when it accompanies grey hairs, and appears in the demeanor of the preacher,—this is indeed a piteous spectacle; and when this can be imitated and followed after, then are the blind leading the blind, then have elders and preacher and people lost their way.

The virtuous man will be of grave and reverent speech; he will think and speak of the absent as he thinks and speaks of the dead—tenderly and sacredly; he will put away thoughtlessness, and watch that he does not sacrifice his dignity to gratify a passing impulse to lightness and frivolity. His mirth will be pure and innocent, and his voice will become subdued and musical, and his soul be filled with grace and sweetness as he succeeds in conducting himself as becomes a man of Truth.

The last step in the second lesson is the overcoming of captiousness, or fault-finding speech. This vice of the tongue consists in magnifying and harping on small or apparent faults, in foolish quibbling and hair-splitting, and in pursuing vain arguments based upon groundless suppositions, beliefs, and opinions. Life is short and real, and sin and sorrow and pain are not remedied by carping and contention. The man who is ever on the watch to catch at the words of others in order to contradict and controvert them, has yet to reach the higher way of holiness, the truer life of self-surrender. The man who is ever on the watch to check his own words in order to soften and purify them will find the higher way and the truer life; he will conserve his energies, maintain his composure of mind, and preserve within himself the spirit of Truth.

When the tongue is well controlled and wisely subdued; when selfish impulses and unworthy thoughts no longer rush to the tongue demanding utterance; when the speech has become harmless, pure, gentle, gracious, and purposeful, and no word is uttered but in sincerity and truth,—then are the five steps in virtuous speech accomplished, then is the second great lesson in Truth learned and mastered.

And now some will ask, "But why all this discipline of the body and restraint of the tongue? Surely the Higher Life can be realized and known without such strenuous labor, such incessant effort and watchfulness?" No, it cannot. In the spiritual as the material, nothing is done without labor, and the higher cannot be known until the lower is fulfilled. Can a man make a table before he has learned how to handle a

tool and drive a nail? And can a man fashion his mind in accordance with Truth before he has overcome the slavery of his body? As the intricate subtleties of language cannot be apprehended and wielded before the alphabet and the simplest words are mastered, neither can the deep subtleties of the mind be understood and purified before the ABC of right conduct is perfectly acquired. As for the labor involved—does not the youth joyfully and patiently submit himself to a seven-years' apprenticeship in order to master a craft? And does he not day by day carefully and faithfully carry out every detail of his master's instructions, looking forward to the time when, perfected through obedience and practice, he shall be himself a master? Where is the man who sincerely aims at excellence in music, painting, literature, in any trade, business, or profession who is not willing to give his whole life to the acquirement of his particular perfection? Shall labor, then, be considered where the very highest excellence is concerned—the excellence of Truth? He who says, "The Path which you point out is too difficult; I must have Truth without labor, salvation without effort," that man will not find his way out of the confusions and sufferings of self-hood; he will not find the calm and well-fortified mind and the wisely ordered life. His love is for ease and enjoyment, and not for Truth. He who, deep in his heart, adores Truth, and aspires to know it, will consider no labor too great to be undertaken, but will adopt it joyfully and pursue it patiently, and by perseverance in practice he will come to the knowledge of Truth.

The necessity for this preliminary discipline of the body and tongue will be the more clearly perceived when it is fully understood that all these wrong outward conditions are merely the expressions of wrong conditions of heart. An indolent body means an indolent mind; an ill-regulated tongue reveals an ill-regulated mind, and the process of remedying the manifested condition is really a method of rectifying the inward state. Moreover, the overcoming of these conditions is only a small part of what is really involved in the process. The ceasing from evil leads to, and is inseparably connected with, the practice of good. While a

man is overcoming indolence and self-indulgence, he is really cultivating and developing the virtues of abstinence, temperance, punctuality, and self-denial, and is acquiring that strength, energy, and resolution which are indispensable to the successful accomplishment of the higher tasks. While he is overcoming the vices of speech, he is developing the virtues of truthfulness, sincerity, reverence, kindliness, and self-control, and is gaining that mental steadiness and fixedness of purpose, without which the remoter subtleties of the mind cannot be regulated, and the higher stages of conduct and enlightenment cannot be reached. Also, as he has to do right, his knowledge deepens, and his insight is intensified, and as the child's heart is glad when his school task is mastered, so with each victory achieved, the man of virtue experiences a bliss which the seeker after pleasure and excitement can never know.

And now we come to the third lesson in the Higher Life, which consists in practising and mastering, in one's daily life, three great fundamental Virtues—(1) Unselfish Performance of Duty; (2) Unswerving Rectitude; and (3) Unlimited Forgiveness. Having prepared the mind by overcoming the more surface and chaotic conditions mentioned in the two first lessons, the striver after Virtue and Truth is now ready to enter upon greater and more difficult tasks, and to control and purify the deeper motives of the heart. Without the right performance of duty, the higher virtues cannot be known, and Truth cannot be apprehended. Duty is generally regarded as an irksome labor, a compulsory something which must be toiled through, or be in some way circumvented. This way of regarding Duty proceeds from a selfish condition of mind, and a wrong understanding of life. All duty should be regarded as sacred, and its faithful and unselfish performance one of the leading rules of conduct. All personal and selfish considerations should be extracted and cast away from the doing of one's duty, and when this is done, Duty ceases to be irksome, and becomes joyful. Duty is only irksome to him who craves some selfish enjoyment or benefit for himself. Let the man who is chafing under the irksomeness of his duty

look to himself, and he will find that his wearisomeness proceeds, not from the duty itself, but from his selfish desire to escape it. He who neglects duty, be it great or small, or of a public or private nature, neglects Virtue; he who in his heart rebels against Duty, rebels against Virtue. When Duty has become a thing of love, and when every particular duty is done accurately, faithfully, and dispassionately, there is much subtle selfishness removed from the heart, and a great step is taken towards the heights of Truth. The virtuous man concentrates his mind on the perfect doing of his own duty, and does not interfere with the duty of another.

The second step in the third lesson is the practice of Unswerving Rectitude. This Virtue must be firmly established in the mind, and so enter into every detail of man's life. All dishonesty, deception, trickery, and misrepresentation must be for ever put away, and the heart be purged of every vestige of insincerity and subterfuge. The least swerving from the path of rectitude is a deviation from Virtue. There must be no extravagance and exaggeration of speech, but the simple truth should be stated. Engaging in deception, no matter how apparently insignificant, for vain-glory, or with the hope of personal advantage, is a state of delusion which one should make efforts to dispel. It is demanded of the man of Virtue that he shall not only practice the most rigid honesty in thought, word, and deed, but that he shall be exact in his statements, omitting and adding nothing to the actual truth. In thus shaping his mind to the principle of Rectitude, he will gradually come to deal with people and things in a just and impartial spirit, considering equity before himself, and viewing all things with freedom from personal bias, passion, and prejudice. When the Virtue of Rectitude is fully practised, acquired, and comprehended, so that all temptation to untruthfulness and insincerity has ceased, then is the heart made purer and nobler, then is character strengthened, and knowledge enlarged, and life takes on a new meaning and a new power. Thus is the second step accomplished.

The third step is the practice of Unlimited Forgiveness. This consists in overcoming the sense of injury which springs from vanity, selfishness, and pride; and in exercising disinterested charity and large-heartedness towards all. Spite, retaliation, and revenge are so utterly ignoble, and so small and foolish, as to be altogether unworthy of being noticed or harbored. No one who fosters such conditions in his heart can lift himself above folly and suffering, and guide his life aright. Only by casting them away, and ceasing to be moved by them, can a man's eyes be opened to the true way in life; only by developing a forgiving and charitable spirit can he hope to approach and perceive the strength and beauty of a well-ordered life. In the heart of the strongly virtuous man no feeling of personal injury can arise; he has put away all retaliation, and has no enemies; and if men should constitute themselves his enemies, he will regard them kindly, understanding their ignorance, and making full allowance for it. When this state of heart is arrived at, then is the third step in the discipline of one's self-seeking inclinations accomplished; then is the third great lesson in Virtue and Knowledge learned and mastered.

Having thus laid down the first ten steps and three lessons in right-doing and right-knowing, I leave those of my readers who are prepared for them to learn and master them in their everyday life. There is, of course, a still higher discipline of the body, a more far-reaching discipline of the tongue, and greater and more all-embracing virtues to acquire and understand before the highest state of bliss and knowledge can be apprehended, but it is not my purpose to deal with them here. I have expounded only the first and easiest lessons on the Higher Path, and by the time these are thoroughly mastered, the reader will have become so purified, strengthened, and enlightened, that he will not be left in the dark as to his future progress. Those of my readers who have completed these three lessons will already have perceived, beyond and above, the high altitudes of Truth, and the narrow and precipitous track which leads to them, and will choose whether they shall proceed.

The straight Path which I have laid down can be pursued by all with greater profit to themselves and to the world, and even those who do not aspire to the attainment of Truth, will develop greater intellectual and moral strength, finer judgment, and deeper peace of mind by perfecting themselves in this Path. Nor will their material prosperity suffer by this change of heart; nay, it will be rendered truer, purer, and more enduring, for if there is one who is capable of succeeding and fitted to achieve, it is the man who has abandoned the petty dissipations and everyday vices of his kind, who is strong to rule his body and his mind, and who pursues with fixed resolve the path of unswerving integrity and sterling virtue.

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REFLECTION

This is Allen's most practical chapter, a starter plan in three lessons. First, discipline of the body: overcome laziness and overeating. Second, discipline of speech: give up slander, gossip, harsh words, mocking talk and fault-finding. Third, discipline of inclination: do your duty without selfishness, be strictly honest, and forgive without limit.

Some of his advice is strict and belongs to his time, such as early rising, fewer meals and no suppers. Read these as invitations to try, not as rules. Eating and sleep needs differ from person to person, and anyone with health concerns should follow medical advice. The heart of the chapter is timeless: watch how you speak about people who are not in the room, tell the plain truth, and let go of grudges. These small steps, Allen promises, build steadiness and peace of mind.

PRACTICE

For one full day, say nothing about an absent person that you would not say to their face. If you slip, simply notice it and start again. In the evening, write down how the day felt.

KEY THOUGHT

He will not say of another that
which he dare not say to him.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

VI

Mental Conditions and their Effects

WITHOUT GOING into the details of the greater steps and lessons in the right life (a task outside the scope of this small work) a few hints and statements concerning those mental conditions from which life in its totality springs, will prove helpful to those who are ready and willing to penetrate further into that inner realm of heart and mind where Love and Wisdom and Peace await the strenuous comer.

All sin is ignorance. It is a condition of darkness and undevelopment. The wrong-thinker and wrong-doer is in the same position in the school of life as is the ignorant pupil in the school of learning. He has yet to learn how to think and act correctly, that is, in accordance with Law. The pupil in learning is not happy so long as he does his lessons wrongly, and unhappiness cannot be escaped while sin remains unconquered.

Life is a series of lessons. Some are diligent in learning them, and they become pure, wise, and altogether happy. Others are negligent, and do not apply themselves, and they remain impure, foolish, and unhappy.

Every form of unhappiness springs from a wrong condition of mind. Happiness inheres in right conditions of mind. Happiness is mental harmony; unhappiness is mental inharmony. While a man lives in wrong conditions of mind, he will live a wrong life, and will suffer continually.

Suffering is rooted in error. Bliss inheres in enlightenment. There is salvation for man only in the destruction of his own ignorance, error, and self-delusion. Where there are wrong conditions of mind there is bondage and unrest; where there are right conditions of mind there is freedom and peace.

Here are some of the leading wrong mental conditions and their disastrous effects upon the life:—

WRONG MENTAL CONDITIONS AND THEIR EFFECTS

- **Hatred.** Injury, violence, disaster, and suffering.
- **Lust.** Confusion of intellect, remorse, shame, and wretchedness.
- **Covetousness.** Fear, unrest, unhappiness, and loss.
- **Pride.** Disappointment, chagrin, lack of self-knowledge.
- **Vanity.** Distress, and mortification of spirit.
- **Condemnation.** Persecution, hatred from others.
- **Ill-will.** Failures and troubles.
- **Self-indulgence.** Misery, loss of judgment, grossness, disease, and neglect.
- **Anger.** Loss of power and influence.
- **Desire, or Self-slavery.** Grief, folly, sorrow, uncertainty, and loneliness.

The above wrong conditions of mind are merely negations; they are states of darkness and deprivation and not of positive power. Evil is not a power; it is ignorance and misuse of good. The hater is he who has failed to do the lesson of Love correctly, and he suffers in consequence. When he succeeds in doing it rightly, the hatred will have disappeared, and he will see and understand the darkness and impotence of hatred. It is so with every wrong condition.

The following are some of the more important right mental conditions and their beneficent effects upon the life:—

RIGHT MENTAL CONDITIONS AND THEIR EFFECTS

- **Love.** Gentle conditions, bliss, and blessedness.
- **Purity.** Intellectual clearness, joy, invincible confidence.
- **Selflessness.** Courage, satisfaction, happiness, and plenty.
- **Humility.** Calmness, restfulness, knowledge of Truth.
- **Meekness.** Equipoise, contentment under all circumstances.
- **Compassion.** Protection, love and reverence from others.
- **Goodwill.** Gladness and success.
- **Self-control.** Peace of mind, true judgment, refinement, health, and honor.
- **Patience.** Mental power, far-reaching influence.
- **Self-conquest.** Enlightenment, wisdom, insight, and profound peace.

The above right conditions of mind are states of positive power, of light, of joyful possession, and of knowledge. The good man knows. He has learned to do his lessons correctly, and thereby understands the exact proportions which make up the sum of life. He is enlightened, and knows good and evil. He is supremely happy, doing only that which is divinely right.

The man who is involved in the wrong conditions of mind, does not know. He is ignorant of good and evil, of himself, of the inward causes which make his life. He is unhappy, and believes other people are entirely the cause of his unhappiness. He works blindly, and lives in darkness, seeing no central purpose in existence, and no orderly and lawful sequence in the course of things.

He who aspires to the attainment of the Higher Life in its completion —who would perceive with unveiled vision the true order of things and the meaning of life—let him abandon all the wrong conditions of heart, and persevere unceasingly in the practice of the good. If he suffers, or doubts, or is unhappy, let him search within until he finds the cause, and having found it, let him cast it away. Let him so guard and purify his

heart that every day less of evil and more of good shall issue therefrom; so will he daily become stronger, nobler, wiser; so will his blessedness increase, and the Light of Truth, growing ever brighter and brighter within him, will dispel all gloom, and illuminate his Pathway.

✦

REFLECTION

Allen sees life as a school and our mistakes as lessons not yet learned. Wrongdoing, in his view, comes from ignorance more than from wickedness. That is a gentle way to look at our own failures and at other people's.

He then gives two lists. One sets out harmful states of mind, such as hatred, pride, anger and greed, together with what they tend to bring. The other sets out helpful states, such as love, humility, patience and self-control, with their fruits. These are best read as moral observations, not as fixed laws: a kind person can still meet trouble, and a proud one may seem to do well for a time. Still, the lists make a useful mirror. When we feel unhappy, Allen asks us to look within for causes we can change, while not ignoring outer causes that are real.

PRACTICE

Read the two lists slowly. Choose one wrong condition you recognize in yourself and the matching right condition. Today, each time you notice the first, take one small action that expresses the second.

KEY THOUGHT

Life is a series of lessons.

MY OWN NOTES

CHAPTER

VII

Exhortation

DISCIPLES of Truth, lovers of Virtue, seekers of Wisdom; ye, also, who are sorrow stricken, knowing the emptiness of the self-life, and who aspire to the life that is supremely beautiful, and serenely glad, —take now yourselves in hand, enter the Door of Discipline, and know the Better Life.

Put away self-delusion; behold yourself as you are, and see the Path of Virtue as it is. There is no lazy way to Truth. He who would stand upon the mountain's summit must strenuously climb, and must rest only to gather strength. But if the climbing is less glorious than the cloudless summit, it is still glorious. Discipline in itself is beautiful, and the end of discipline is sweet.

Rise early and meditate. Begin each day with a conquered body, and a mind fortified against error and weakness. Temptation will never be overcome by unprepared fighting. The mind must be armed and arrayed in the silent hour. It must be trained to perceive, to know, to understand. Sin and temptation disappear when right understanding is developed.

Right understanding is reached through unabated discipline. Truth cannot be reached but through discipline. Patience will increase by effort and practice, and patience will make discipline beautiful.

Discipline is irksome to the impatient man and the self-lover, so he avoids it, and continues to live loosely and confusedly.

Discipline is not irksome to the Truth-lover, and he will find the infinite patience which can wait and work and overcome. As the joy of the gardener who sees his flowers develop day by day, so is the joy of the man of discipline who sees the divine flowers of Purity, Wisdom, Compassion, and Love, grow up in his heart.

The loose-liver cannot escape sorrow and pain. The undisciplined mind falls, weak and helpless, before the fierce onslaught of passion.

Array well your mind, then, lover of Truth. Be watchful, thoughtful, resolute. Your salvation is at hand; your readiness and effort are all that are needed. If you should fail ten times, do not be disheartened; if you should fail a hundred times, rise up and pursue your way; if you should fail a thousand times, do not despair. When the right Path is entered, success is sure if the Path is not utterly abandoned.

First strife, and then victory. First labor, and then rest. First weakness, and then strength. In the beginning the lower life, and the glare and confusion of battle, and at the end the Life Beautiful, the Silence, and the Peace.

✦

REFLECTION

Allen ends with a short, warm call to action. He speaks to seekers and also to people who are hurting, and he says: take yourself in hand and begin. There is no lazy way to truth, he admits, but the climb has its own beauty, and discipline itself can be sweet.

His advice to rise early and meditate is an invitation to begin each day on purpose, with a quiet hour before the noise. His most encouraging lines are about failure. Fail ten times, a hundred, a thousand, and keep going. The path is only lost if we abandon it. For modern readers, this is permission to be

imperfect and persistent. The book closes with a rhythm of hope: first effort, then rest; first weakness, then strength; and at the end, peace.

PRACTICE

Tomorrow morning, set aside five quiet minutes before you look at a screen. Sit, breathe and name one intention for the day. If you forget, start again the next morning without blame.

KEY THOUGHT

If you should fail ten times, do not be disheartened

MY OWN NOTES

The 30-Day Practice

Allen believed that the mind changes the way a garden does: slowly, through small daily care, not through one heroic afternoon. This month-long practice is built on that idea. Each day gives you one short passage from the two books, a reminder of where it comes from, and a simple task that takes only a few minutes. There is room to write below each day.

The month has a shape. In the first week you simply notice your thoughts, without trying to fix them. In the second you look at how thinking connects with your circumstances and choices, and you begin to work with purpose. The third week turns to habit, speech and gentle discipline. The fourth looks outward and upward, to vision, calm and kindness. The last two days are for looking back.

A few suggestions. Read the day's passage in the morning and carry it with you. Do the task in the most ordinary setting you can, at work, at home, in traffic. In the evening, write a line or two about what you noticed. If you miss a day, do not start over; just pick up where you left off. Allen's own advice applies here: if you fail, rise up and keep going.

None of these exercises is a test, and none is a replacement for medical or psychological care. They are invitations to pay closer attention to your own mind, with honesty and with kindness toward yourself.

DAY

1

The Seed of Every Act

every act of a man springs from the hidden seeds of thought, and could not have appeared without them.

THOUGHT AND CHARACTER

Today, pick three ordinary actions, such as a text you send, a purchase, a sharp or kind word. For each, pause afterward and ask: what thought came just before this? Write the three thoughts down without judging them.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

2

Tending the Garden

so may a man tend the garden of his mind, weeding out all the wrong, useless, and impure thoughts

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Set a reminder for three times today. Each time it goes off, notice what you were just thinking. Was it a flower, a weed or simply grass? Do not pull anything up yet; just get to know the garden.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

3

The Watcher

Man is the keeper of his heart; the watcher of his mind; the solitary sentinel of his citadel of life.

THE HEART AND THE LIFE

When worry or irritation shows up today, try naming it quietly: "There is worry." Notice that the one who names the thought is not the same as the thought. Write down one moment when this gave you a little space.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

4

Tracing the Effects

if he will watch, control, and alter his thoughts, tracing their effects upon himself, upon others, and upon his life and circumstances

THOUGHT AND CHARACTER

Choose one thought that keeps coming back this week. Trace it: how does it make your body feel, how does it change the way you treat people, and what does it lead you to do or avoid? Write a short chain: thought, feeling, action.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

5

The Weaver

Mind clothes itself in garments of its own making.

THE NATURE AND POWER OF MIND

Notice one story you tell yourself about who you are, such as "I'm not a morning person" or "I always mess this up." Write it down. Then ask: is this a fact, or a garment I keep putting on?

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

6

Body and Mind

If you would protect your body, guard your mind.

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON HEALTH AND THE BODY

Today, notice where stress or worry lands in your body: jaw, shoulders, stomach, breath. When you catch it, take three slow breaths and relax that spot. This is care, not cure; for any health concern, talk to a doctor.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

7

Finding the Good

to think well of all, to be cheerful with all,
to patiently learn to find the good in all

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON HEALTH AND THE BODY

Think of one person who tends to annoy you. Today, look for one genuinely good thing about them and write it down. Then look back over this first week: which thoughts did you notice most often?

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

8

Choosing Thoughts

he can choose his thoughts, and so indirectly, yet surely, shape his circumstances.

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Name one situation in your life that you cannot change directly. Then list two thoughts about it that you can choose, and one small action each thought would lead to. Pick one action and do it today.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

9

What Circumstance Reveals

Circumstance does not make the man; it reveals him to himself

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Recall a recent difficult moment. Without blaming yourself for the difficulty itself, ask what your response showed you: a strength you did not expect, or a habit you want to change. Write one sentence about each.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

10

No One Can See the Whole

a man's entire soul-condition (although it may be known to himself) cannot be judged by another from the external aspect of his life alone.

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Allen himself warns against judging people by their outward lives. Today, each time you catch yourself judging someone's situation, remind yourself that you are seeing only a small part of their story. Note how often it happens.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

11

A Change of Approach

as he alters his thoughts towards things and other people, things and other people will alter towards him.

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Choose one relationship that feels stuck. Before your next contact with that person, decide on one fresh, generous thought about them. Carry it into the conversation and notice whether anything shifts, in them or in you.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

12

A Purpose of Your Own

A man should conceive of a legitimate purpose in his heart, and set out to accomplish it.

THOUGHT AND PURPOSE

Write down one purpose for the next three months. It can be small: finish a course, repair a friendship, walk every day. Then write the very first step, one you could take this week, and put it in your calendar.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

13

The Task in Front of You

fix the thoughts upon the faultless performance of their duty, no matter how insignificant their task may appear.

THOUGHT AND PURPOSE

Choose one dull task today: dishes, email, a form. Do it with full attention, as well as you can, without rushing toward the next thing. Afterward, note how it felt to give a small task your whole mind.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

14

Lifting Your Thoughts

A man can only rise, conquer, and achieve by lifting up his thoughts.

THE THOUGHT-FACTOR IN ACHIEVEMENT

When you catch a thought that pulls you down today, such as "What's the point?" or "I can't," answer it with a truer, more hopeful one, and write both down. Then review the week: where did thinking and circumstance meet?

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

15

How Habits Form

A thought constantly repeated at last
becomes a fixed habit of the mind,
and from such habits proceeds the life.

FORMATION OF HABIT

Write down one thought you repeat almost every day. Is it a habit you want to keep? If not, write a short replacement thought and repeat it on purpose five times today, at set moments.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

16

Calm Can Be Learned

Calmness and patience can become habitual in the same way

FORMATION OF HABIT

Pick one daily moment that usually makes you impatient, such as a queue, a slow computer or a child's dawdling. Today, meet it with one slow breath and a patient thought. Count how many times you managed it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

17

The Lowest and Easiest Step

it is necessary to commence at the lowest and easiest steps, and proceed by natural and progressive stages to the higher and more difficult.

DOING AND KNOWING

Think of a change you have tried and given up. Make the first step so small it is almost silly: one push-up, one line in a journal, one minute of quiet. Do that small step today and tick it off.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

18

Knowing by Doing

Virtue can only be known by doing

DOING AND KNOWING

Choose one quality you admire, such as patience, generosity or honesty. Instead of thinking about it, do one specific act of it today. In the evening, write what you learned from doing it that you did not know from reading about it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

19

Keeping What You Gain

Victories attained by right thought can only be maintained by watchfulness.

THE THOUGHT-FACTOR IN ACHIEVEMENT

Recall one good change you have already made in your life. What keeps it alive? Write one small daily or weekly habit that protects it, and do that habit today.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

20

Speaking of the Absent

He will not say of another that which he dare not say to him.

FIRST STEPS IN THE HIGHER LIFE

For one whole day, say nothing about anyone who is not present that you would not say to their face. If you slip, simply notice and stop mid-sentence if you can. Write down how often the urge came.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

21

Softening Your Words

The man who is ever on the watch to check his own words in order to soften and purify them will find the higher way and the truer life

FIRST STEPS IN THE HIGHER LIFE

Before sending any message today, read it once more and soften one word or remove one unnecessary barb. In a tense conversation, pause for a breath before answering. Then look back over this week of habit and speech.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

22

Seedlings

Dreams are the seedlings of realities.

VISIONS AND IDEALS

Spend ten quiet minutes picturing a life you would be glad to grow into, not in terms of things you own, but of the person you would be. Write a short paragraph describing it. Keep it somewhere you will see it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

23

Effort, Not Luck

the strength of the effort is the measure of the result.

VISIONS AND IDEALS

Think of someone whose life you admire and who seems "lucky." Find out, or imagine honestly, the work and setbacks behind it. Then name one effort, however modest, you will put toward your own vision today.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

24

The Helm

Self-control is strength; Right Thought is mastery; Calmness is power.

SERENITY

Choose one moment today when you would normally react quickly: an email, a comment, a bit of bad news. Wait ten seconds before you respond. Note what you said or did differently because of the pause.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

25

A Sheltering Presence

He is like a shade-giving tree in a thirsty land, or a sheltering rock in a storm.

SERENITY

Be a steady presence for one person today. Listen to them fully without fixing, advising or interrupting. Afterward, write a line about what it felt like to offer calm rather than reaction.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

26

Forgiveness

exercising disinterested charity
and large-heartedness towards all

FIRST STEPS IN THE HIGHER LIFE

Think of a small grievance you are still carrying. Write it down, and then write one sentence of goodwill toward the person involved. Forgiving does not mean excusing harm or staying in danger; it means setting down a weight you no longer need to carry.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

27

Habits of Kindness

beautiful thoughts of all kinds crystallize into habits of grace and kindliness

EFFECT OF THOUGHT ON CIRCUMSTANCES

Do three small kind things today that no one asked for: a thank-you note, a held door, a generous word. Notice how each one changes your own mood as well as the other person's.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

28

A Little Better Each Day

every day less of evil and more
of good shall issue therefrom

MENTAL CONDITIONS AND THEIR EFFECTS

Tonight, write down one thing you did today that you are glad of and one thing you would do differently. Keep both short and honest, without harshness. Then look back over this week of vision, calm and kindness.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

29

Rising Again

If you should fail ten times, do not be disheartened; if you should fail a hundred times, rise up and pursue your way

EXHORTATION

Read back through your notes from the past four weeks. Mark the days that went well and the days that did not. Choose one practice that slipped and give it another try today, without self-reproach.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

DAY

30

The Sweetness of Discipline

Discipline in itself is beautiful,
and the end of discipline is sweet.

EXHORTATION

Write a short letter to yourself: what you noticed this month, which practice helped most, and the one practice you want to keep. Choose that practice for the coming month, and decide when and where you will do it.

TODAY I WILL

☐ read ☐ watched my thoughts ☐ one kind act

Quick Finder

When you come to this book with something particular on your mind, start here: each situation points to the chapters and practice days that speak most directly to it.

When worry takes over — Serenity; Mental Conditions and their Effects · Days 3, 24

When you feel stuck in your circumstances — Effect of Thought on Circumstances; Visions and Ideals · Days 8, 9

When you are drifting without direction — Thought and Purpose · Days 12, 13

When you doubt you can do it — Thought and Purpose; The Thought-Factor in Achievement · Day 14

When your temper gets the better of you — Serenity; Formation of Habit · Days 16, 24

When you want to break a bad habit — Formation of Habit; Doing and Knowing · Days 15, 17

When you keep starting over and giving up — Doing and Knowing; Exhortation · Days 17, 29

When you are tempted to gossip or criticize — First Steps in the Higher Life · Days 20, 21

When you are holding a grudge — First Steps in the Higher Life · Day 26

When stress shows up in your body — Effect of Thought on Health and the Body · Day 6

When you are quick to judge others — Effect of Thought on Circumstances; The Nature and Power of Mind · Days 7, 10

When a relationship feels stuck — Effect of Thought on Circumstances · Day 11

When you envy someone's "luck" — Visions and Ideals · Day 23

When you need a bigger vision for your life — Visions and Ideals · Day 22

When the same negative thought keeps returning — Thought and Character; The Heart and the Life · Days 3, 4

When you feel your life is shaped only by outside forces — The Nature and Power of Mind; Effect of Thought on Circumstances · Days 5, 8

When you have failed again — Exhortation; Thought and Purpose · Days 19, 29

When an everyday task feels pointless — Thought and Purpose; First Steps in the Higher Life · Day 13

When you want to start the day well — Exhortation; First Steps in the Higher Life · Day 18

When success makes you careless — The Thought-Factor in Achievement · Day 19

When someone near you needs steadiness — Serenity · Day 25

When you want to be kinder — Mental Conditions and their Effects; Effect of Thought on Circumstances · Days 27, 28

When discipline feels like a burden — Exhortation; Doing and Knowing · Day 30

A Glossary

Almshouse — a house paid for by charity where poor people, often the elderly, could live. In Allen's day it stood for falling into poverty.

Aphorism — a short, memorable saying that states a general truth, such as "As a man thinketh in his heart so is he."

Bark — an old word for a small sailing ship or boat. Allen pictures the mind as a boat on "the ocean of life."

Captiousness — the habit of picking at small faults in what others say, nitpicking and arguing for the sake of it.

Character — the settled shape of a person's inner life: their usual ways of thinking, feeling and choosing. For Allen it is built from thoughts over time.

Circumstance — the outward conditions of a life: home, work, money, health, relationships and events.

Citadel — a fortress that protects a city. Allen calls the heart the "citadel of life," a place to guard.

Dhammapada — an early collection of the Buddha's sayings in verse. The lines quoted in "Thought and Character" come from it.

Divine — belonging to or coming from God. Allen uses it for the highest goodness a person can grow toward.

Dross — the waste that rises to the top when metal is melted and purified; anything worthless that must be removed.

Equipoise — a state of balance, mental and emotional steadiness.

Extirpate — to pull up by the roots; to remove completely.

Fortitude — strength of mind to endure pain, hardship or danger with courage. Allen's "fortified" mind is one that has this strength.

Frugality — living simply and avoiding waste, especially with food and money.

Gaoler — the British spelling of "jailer."

Garner — to gather in and store, as a farmer gathers a harvest.

Gustatory — having to do with taste and eating.

Higher Life — Allen's term in *Out from the Heart* for a life of steady virtue, self-control and spiritual growth.

Husbandry — farming; the careful work of tending land and crops.

Ilfracombe — a seaside town on the north coast of Devon, England, where Allen lived and wrote.

Importunity — persistent, even pestering, asking. Allen uses it for refusing to give up the search for truth.

Indigence — poverty; lacking the basic necessities of life.

Indolence — laziness; avoiding effort and putting things off.

Levity — lightness or flippancy where seriousness or respect is called for.

The Light of Reason — the magazine Allen wrote and edited in Ilfracombe, later renamed *The Epoch*.

New Thought — a movement of the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries that taught that the mind powerfully influences health, character and life.

Rectitude — moral uprightness; honesty and fairness in everything one does.

Sentinel — a soldier who stands guard and keeps watch.

Thinketh — the old English form of "thinks," as in the King James Bible.

Viands — food, especially rich or choice dishes.

Vicissitudes — ups and downs; changes of fortune.

Warp and woof — the lengthwise and crosswise threads of woven cloth; together, the basic structure of something.

Will-o'-the-wisp — a flickering light seen over marshes at night, said to lead travelers astray; any false hope or misleading goal.

Afterword: The Gardener of the Mind

There is a reason the garden is the image people remember from James Allen. It is honest about how change really happens.

No gardener makes a rose. A gardener prepares the soil, plants, waters, pulls weeds, waits, and then does it all again the next day. Much of what decides the harvest, the weather, the soil they inherited, a late frost, is outside their hands. And yet the garden that is tended looks nothing like the garden that is left alone. The difference is not luck or force. It is attention, kept up over time.

That is the heart of what Allen offers. He asks us to notice the thoughts we let grow, to choose some on purpose, and to keep returning to that choice on ordinary days. He does not ask for a sudden transformation. He asks for a small daily faithfulness, the kind that turns a difficult thought into a natural one, as he puts it, the way a child's clumsy handwriting slowly becomes easy.

It is worth remembering what the image does not say. A gardener whose crop is ruined by a storm has not failed. A garden planted in poor ground is not to blame for its soil. Allen sometimes wrote as if every hardship were self-made, and a modern reader can respectfully set that part aside. Illness, injustice and loss are real, and they come to good people. What remains in our keeping is the gardener's part: how we meet what comes, what we plant next, and how we treat the people working the plots beside ours.

If you have worked through these pages, you have already been gardening. Perhaps you caught a worry before it took over, softened a sharp word, or did a dull task with care. These things are small. They are also exactly the material Allen says a life is made of.

So keep going, gently. Return to a chapter when you need it. Repeat a week of the practice when you drift. Be as patient with your own mind as a good gardener is with a slow-growing tree. The work is never quite finished, but, as Allen says, it is beautiful in itself, and its fruit is sweet.

Further Reading

More by James Allen

From Poverty to Power (1901) — Allen's first book, a longer treatment of many of the themes in this volume.

The Way of Peace

The Path of Prosperity

An older voice on the same path

Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, translated by George Long (1862) — the private notebook of a Roman emperor training his own mind in calm, duty and self-command.

New Thought classics in this annotated series

Florence Scovel Shinn, *Your Word Is Your Wand* (1928)

Christian D. Larson, *Your Forces and How to Use Them* (1912)

William Walker Atkinson, *Thought Vibration* (1906)

Prentice Mulford, *Thoughts Are Things*